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Tuesday, July 28, 2026

Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

WILL ENSURE TRANSPARENCY IN RAM TEMPLE DONATIONS: SC

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said it will take "remedial steps to ensure transparency" in the management of donations received at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, while making it clear that its immediate priority was to ensure a "speedy, qualitative and impartial investigation in a timebound manner" into allegations of embezzlement of devotees' contributions. →P5

HC QUASHES TN ORDER GRANTING GOVT JOBS TO KIN OF KARUR VICTIMS

Ayesha Arvind
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BANGALORE: The Madras high court on Monday struck down a Tamil Nadu government order granting compassionate appointments to the families of the people who died in the September 2025 Karur stampede. →P5

RAGGING CASES AT COLLEGES SURGED OVER 100% SINCE 2022, LS INFORMED

Himanshi Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Ragging complaints from higher educational institutions across India climbed to 1,369 in 2025, marking an over 100% increase from 655 cases in 2022, the Centre informed the Lok Sabha on Monday, maintaining that its response to the problem remains "corrective and preventive." →P11

IIT-G STUDENT FALLS TO HIS DEATH ON CAMPUS, POLICE SUSPECT SUICIDE

Biswa Kalyan Purkayastha
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SILCHAR: A BTech student at IIT-Guwahati died on Sunday after allegedly falling from the fifth floor of the institute's hostel building, police said on Monday, adding that they have launched a probe and are looking into the possibility of suicide. →P7

DELHI POLICE SEEKS DEATH PENALTY FOR TAHIR HUSSAIN OVER IB STAFFER'S MURDER

Arnabjit Sur
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NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Monday sought the death penalty for ex-AAP councillor Tahir Hussain and four others convicted in the murder of IB staffer Ankit Sharma during the Delhi riots.

After protests, Parliament to debate tougher paper leak bill

Saubhadra Chatterji and Smriti Kak Ramachandran
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NEW DELHI: A stringent bill that hikes fines and punishment for those convicted of examination paper leaks is set to be debated in Parliament on Tuesday, a day after it was introduced in the Lok Sabha amid protests by the Opposition that sought to corner the government over police violence during the recent student protests.

Union minister Jitendra Singh introduced the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill — which aims for stricter punishment, hikes the minimum jail term and quantum of fines, and promises speedy trials by setting up fast-track courts — but the Opposition's vociferous protests drowned the ruling side's efforts to push through the bill twice.

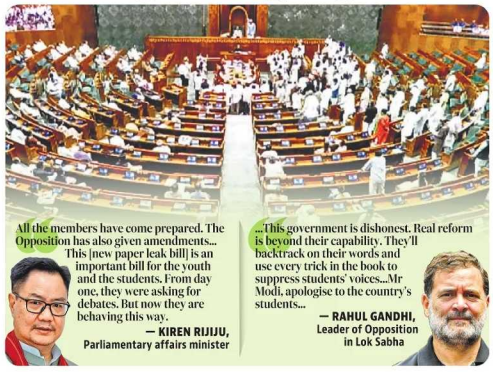
The united Opposition sought accountability from Union home minister Amit Shah over allegations of police excesses and the use of pellet guns during the sweeping protests over paper leaks on July 20 that brought the Capital to a halt and ultimately led to the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Saturday.

In the evening, officials said that after discussions with speaker Om Birla, all major political parties agreed to discuss the bill starting Tuesday.

"During the proceedings, speaker Om Birla urged all parties to recognise that the issue concerns millions of students and youths across the country, as well as the integrity and transparency of competitive examinations. Therefore, a comprehensive and meaningful discussion on the matter was deemed appropriate," said an official, requesting anonymity.

"Following this positive initiative, the Lok Sabha speaker personally engaged with the floor leaders of various political parties. Consequently, both the ruling party and the Opposition reached a consensus to hold a detailed discussion on the bill on Tuesday. This move has fur-

continued on →9



All the members have come prepared. The Opposition has also given amendments... This [new paper leak bill] is an important bill for the youth and the students. From day one, they were asking for debates. But now they are behaving this way.
— KIREN RIJIJU, Parliamentary affairs minister

...This government is dishonest. Real reform is beyond their capability. They'll backtrack on their words and use every trick in the book to suppress students' voices...Mr Modi, apologise to the country's students...
— RAHUL GANDHI, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha

morestories

- Bihar constable suspended for 'using AK-47' →P6
- 20 FIRs filed in Delhi over CJP protest violence
- Reforms lag 2 years after NEET panel report →P5

BIHAR ASSURES PROTESTERS: FIRs BEING DROPPED, NO LEGAL ACTION

PATNA: The Bihar government on Monday said it will withdraw all cases registered against protesters and release those arrested during a statewide crackdown on demonstrators who took part in the agitation called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

In a statement, the state government said it will not take any legal action against people who participated in protests before 6pm on July 26. "No adverse legal action... shall be taken by the Government against any individual participating in the protests before 6 PM on July 26, across the entire state," a notification issued by the state home department said. →P6

CJP warns of fresh stir over detentions, FIRs

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday said students and protesters were being detained or arrested in various states, particularly Assam, Bihar and West Bengal, in violation of the agreement with the Centre last week, and threatened to return to street protests if it didn't stop.

The withdrawal of all cases and FIRs was part of the conditions – the others being the resignation of former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan and ₹1 crore compensation to the families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide – involved in calling off the Jantar Mantar stir on Saturday.

"Dear @JPNadda, @DrJitendraSingh ji, we are observing a complete breach of the agreement regarding no police action against the protestors...we demand that all the FIRs against the protestors be immediately withdrawn, students be released and no future FIRs be filed...failing which we will be forced to sit on protest again," CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka said. →P6

SC decries both police excesses, stir violence

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday indicated that it may frame nationwide guidelines governing the handling of protests, observing that while the constitutional right to peaceful protest must be protected, violence by demonstrators and excessive use of force by police were equally unacceptable.

A bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said that it was equally concerned about injuries suffered by protesters and police personnel during demonstrations, and stressed that "self-imposed discipline" by protesters and police personnel was integral to a functioning democracy.

"...If there are excesses committed, that can be looked into dispassionately...who has done it etc...It is not a question of Delhi alone but it is an all-India issue. It cannot be that there is an agitation and hence a lathi charge. It can also not be that violence occurs in these protests," justice Kant added. →P6

SPL FAST TRACK COURT FOR PAPER LEAK CASES ADJOURNED AS NO PROSECUTOR APPEARS

The first day of the fast-track court designated to exclusively hear paper leak cases at Rouse Avenue Court on Monday saw an adjournment after no prosecutor appeared on behalf of CBI to argue on bail proceedings. Special judge Anu Grover Baliga was hearing the bail petitions of Dinesh and Vikas Biwal, two of the 13 accused in the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case. The matter is the first case to be assigned to the newly formed court. In its order, the court noted that no one appeared on behalf of the state till 10.45am to argue on the bail application. HTC

A dozen RAF personnel issued pellet guns: Probe

Prawesh Lama
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NEW DELHI: At least a dozen personnel of the Rapid Action Force(RAF) were issued pellet guns on the morning of July 20 to handle student protesters in the Capital but the controversial weapons were withdrawn starting July 23 after allegations that they were used against the demonstrators, officials aware of RAF's internal inquiry said on Monday. →P6

Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel during the July 20 protest in Delhi. AFP

HC TO HEAR TODAY PLEA ON POLICE SURVEILLANCE OF PROTESTERS

The Delhi High Court will hear on Tuesday a petition alleging police surveillance of protesters at the stir against the NEET-UG questions leak. "Things have cooled down, let them cool down further," the court observed during a hearing on Monday, and suggested a comprehensive petition seeking guidelines for such police surveillance practices be filed. The court observed that such a petition would enable them to examine the existing framework governing police surveillance and assess the provisions in place.

S Delhi building collapse report flags MCD lapses

Saloni Bhatia
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NEW DELHI: Officials of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi didn't monitor or crack down on illegal construction, sat on multiple complaints, failed to enforce norms and later fabricated retrospective inspection records to mislead investigators, a magisterial inquiry into the collapse of an unauthorised building in south Delhi's Saidulajab in May has found.

The 80-page inquiry report into the accident — where a four-storey building collapsed on May 30 when two additional floors were under construction, burying a canteen, damaging a neighbouring coaching institute, and killing six people — concluded that the disaster was preventable.

It cleared the Delhi Police, Delhi Jal Board and power discom BSES of any wrongdoing, but flagged that one person was shuttled between multiple hospitals in the critical hours before his death.

"The collapse primarily resulted from unauthorised structural additions and inadequate regulatory enforcement...most significant deficiencies were found in the monitoring and enforcement mechanism of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi," said the

continued on →9

On May 30, a building in south Delhi's Saidulajab collapsed, killing six people. HT PHOTO

DELHI COURT GRANTS BAIL TO B&B COOK IN HAUZ RANI FIRE CASE

A Delhi court on Monday granted bail to Keshar Negi, 65, the cook at the Hauz Rani bed-and-breakfast who was arrested after a fire at the facility killed 23 people in June. "The mere fact that the applicant was required... to operate kitchen appliances... cannot, by itself, lead to an inference that he was criminally negligent or legally responsible for the unfortunate incident," additional sessions judge Samar Vishal of the Saket courts said. Lavkesh Bajaj, the facility's owner, and Jay Mishra, in whose name the B&B licence was issued, remain in judicial custody.

In deep talks with Iran, strong action if it does not work out: Trump

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WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said he decided to pause strikes on Iran to give negotiations another chance, minimizing the prospect of a potential military escalation of the war.

Trump said Monday in an interview with Axios that "very deep talks" are taking place with the Islamic Republic and "if they don't work out, we will go back to very strong military action."

Over the course of the war, Trump has repeatedly said talks were progressing and that a deal was close. But it's unclear if any substantial negotiations between the US and Iran were taking place.

His comments came after the

US President Donald Trump

US held off attacking Iran for a third straight day on Monday, despite making threats last week about a major new attack. Tehran, in turn, paused strikes on Gulf countries such as Kuwait. The two sides had returned to fighting after an interim peace deal signed last month effec-

continued on →9

Proceeds in Mahadev app case may touch ₹43k-cr

Abhishek Sharan
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MUMBAI: Mahadev Online Book (MOB) and associated platforms like Skyexchange and Lotus 365 have generated proceeds of crime (POC) in the range of ₹36,000 to ₹43,400 crore through alleged illegal betting operations in the last seven years, said Enforcement Directorate (ED) officials.

This is the first consolidated provisional estimation of proceeds of crime of MOB and its allied betting platforms since ED began its investigation in October 2022. So far, the agency has filed five chargesheets against 74 persons and entities in the PMLA court at Raipur, Chhattisgarh.

Investigators said MOB — one of the largest illegal betting syndicates operating through franchise-based networks — generated over ₹450 crore every month which was then laundered through a layered network of shell entities, accommodation entries and financial transactions to disguise the funds as legitimate. →P7

INDIGO AIRCRAFT MAKES EMERGENCY LANDING IN RAJKOT AFTER SMOKE ALERT

AHMEDABAD: A Delhi-Mumbai IndiGo flight made an emergency landing in Rajkot on Monday after the flight crew reported detecting smoke in the aircraft's cargo hold, officials said.

"All 185 passengers, including two infants, and seven crew members are safe. The pilots detected smoke in the cargo area, following which the aircraft made an emergency landing at Rajkot. The aircraft has been taken for inspection," said Rajkot collector and district magistrate Om Prakash. →P7

Problems with anti-defection law are making of MPs, says top court

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: Observing that "enormous issues" in the implementation of the anti-defection law are "the making of the members of Parliament", the Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a plea by senior advocate Kapil Sibal assailing the interpretation of a provision that allows legislators to escape disqualification by taking the route of a political party merger.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe issued notice on a petition filed by Sibal in his own name, questioning the interpretation of Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution that permits disqualification to be avoided where legislators claim protection under the merger provision, requiring a two-thirds threshold and allowing members to either join the new group or leave.

While agreeing to tag the matter with a similar pending case relating to the Goa political defections before a three-judge bench, Justice Narasimha remarked that although there were "enormous issues" with the working of the Tenth Schedule, the law was framed by Parliament itself. →P8

TOP COURT AGREES TO HEAR PLEA AGAINST PROVISION THAT ALLOWS MPs TO ESCAPE DISQUALIFICATION VIA PARTY MERGER

HDFC BANK BOARD FINES 3 TOP EXECS ₹1L IN MSRDC CASE

MUMBAI: The board of HDFC Bank on Monday issued warning letters and levied a ₹1 lakh penalty on three top executives of the bank as an internal review into the bank's arrangement with the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) for garnering deposits found that the employees' conduct amounted to business overreach rather than any mala fide action. →P12

BANK OF BARODA CUSTOMER DATA LEAKED IN BREACH

MUMBAI: A cyber breach at Bank of Baroda has reportedly exposed about 1TB of customer and internal data, with the bank saying on Monday that the incident stemmed from the compromise of an employee's email account. →P12

VICTIM OF 'DIGITAL ARREST' TOOK COPS FOR IMPOSTERS

MUMBAI: A Mumbai cyber police team had to convince a 75-year-old Grant Road resident they were genuine officers after he trusted fraudsters running a fake cop scam. The victim had transferred ₹1.64 crore before police, aided by local residents, intervened on July 25. →P8

{ MANUAL SCAVENGING DEATHS }

SC contempt notices to 15 state chief secretaries

Abraham Thomas
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday issued contempt notices to chief secretaries of 14 states and Delhi, for their failure to prevent manual scavenging deaths despite a clear direction by the top court in 2023 ruling to end this practice.

Referring to data from the Centre's response to a Parliament question in March this year, a bench of justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi noted a total of 165 deaths reported from 15 states, with 65 in 2023, 54 in 2024, and 46 in 2025.

The bench said, "Despite this court's directions issued on October 20, 2023, deaths due to persons entering sewer/septic tanks is still occurring and that too in large numbers."

Refusing to tolerate continuation of human scavenging, the bench categorically asserted, "Such deaths cannot go on when we have made it clear that no manual scavenging is to take place." →P5

ONE DEAD, THREE FEARED DROWNED IN YAMUNA NEAR GEETA COLONY

Karn Pratap Singh
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NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old man died and at least three others were feared to have drowned in the Yamuna near east Delhi's Geeta Colony on Monday, fire and police officials said.

It was not immediately known how the four fell into the river. The body of one victim has been retrieved, while the search for the three others was suspended around 10pm due to darkness. The search will resume on Tuesday morning, officials said.

India's weightlifters continue to do the heavy lifting, bring home three more CWG medals

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: India added three more medals to its Commonwealth Games weightlifting haul in 24 hours, with Raja Muthupandi claiming silver in the men's 65kg division, Gyaneshwari Yadav winning silver in the women's 53kg category, Bindyarani Devi taking bronze in the women's 58kg event.

Tamil Nadu's Muthupandi totalled 286kg (126kg+160kg) to finish behind Malaysia's Azril Bin Bidin Muhamad late on Sunday. On Monday, Chhattisgarh's Yadav lifted a personal-best 199kg (88kg+111kg) but finished second to Nigeria's Onome Omolola Didih, who set a Games record with 206kg. Manipur's Devi recovered from a modest snatch to total 199kg (87kg+112kg) and clinch bronze in the women's 58kg category, taking India's total weightlifting medal tally to five and overall CWG haul to six till the time of going to print. →P14

Gyaneshwari Yadav; Raja Muthupandi; Bindyarani Devi PTI/ANI

WANTED TO SHOW THAT I CAN WIN THIS EVENT: ANAHAT SINGH

Anahat Singh capped her junior career by winning the World Junior Squash Championship in Ontario, becoming the first Indian to claim the title. The 18-year-old said the triumph ended years of frustration after repeated close finishes. "...I would always lose coming really close to it. I wanted to break that, and show that I can win this event. It's something that I wanted to tick off." →P13

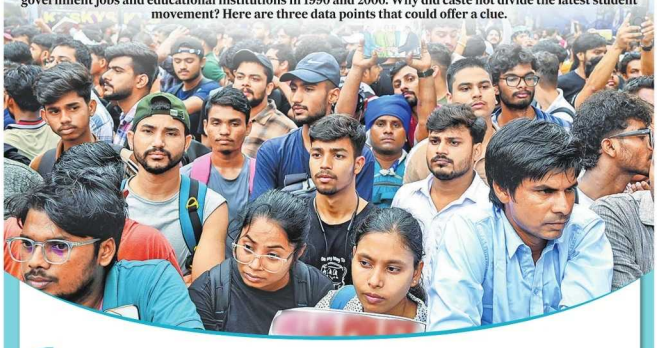
PAGE ONE PLUS

NUMBER THEORY

Locating the other C(aste) in the Cockroach movement

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

The recently concluded students' protests in India under the banner of the "Cockroach Janta Party" were the biggest in a long time in the country. They were also remarkable in another respect. The defining C in Indian politics, namely caste, did not exist as an antagonistic fault line in this movement. By contrast, two of India's biggest students' unrests were built exclusively along caste lines, when the V.P. Singh and Manmohan Singh governments implemented Other Backward Class (OBC) reservations in central government jobs and educational institutions in 1990 and 2006. Why did caste not divide the latest student movement? Here are three data points that could offer a clue.

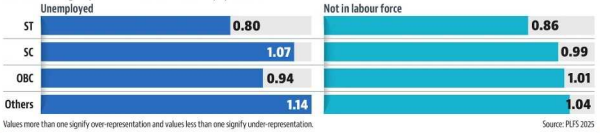


1 Upper castes have a bigger relative share in the ranks of unemployed and out-of-labour-force in India than SC, ST or OBCs

Reservations are now widely accepted as a fait accompli in India irrespective of one's ideological position. That the current government also rolled out reservations for Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) among communities ineligible for caste-based reservations in 2019, and that this evoked almost unanimous support across political lines, was essentially a rejection of the so-called meritocratic argument against reservations. With the debate largely settled on reservations, students are perhaps more focused on the state of play as it exists. Here, the so-called upper caste students – those who do not belong to Scheduled Caste (SC), Scheduled Tribe (ST) or OBC groups – have reason to believe that they are the worst affected by the broken link between India's education and employment as their relative share (adjusted for share in population) is the highest among major groups in both unemployed and out-of-labour-force population. To be sure, this lack of privilege comes from a privilege, as explained below.

Share in unemployed and out-of-labour-force population relative to share in total population

Ratio of social group's share in status and total population



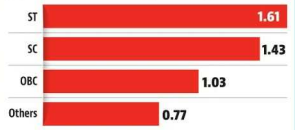
Values more than one signify over-representation and values less than one signify under-representation. Source: PLFS 2025

2 Among the college educated, the probability of being unemployed flips against SC-ST-OBCs

As we explained in these pages last week, unemployment in India is primarily a result of holding out for a job that matches expectations. Education is a key driver of such expectations. If one were to compare social-group-wise relative share among the unemployed among the college educated, it is the SC, ST, OBCs who do badly than the non-SC-ST-OBCs. The latter group, in fact, is the least likely to be unemployed, underlining the socio-economic hierarchy in India. The short point is that educated communities eligible for caste-based reservations are also angry with the education system.

Share in unemployed relative to share in population among graduates

Ratio of social group's share in unemployed and total population for those educated up to at least graduate level



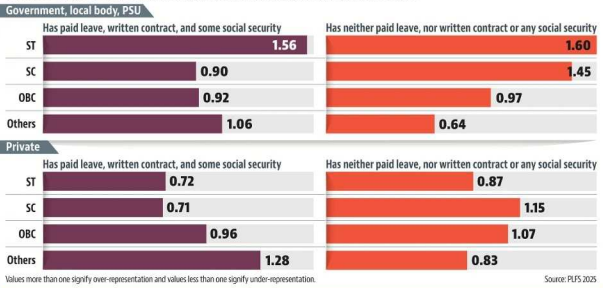
Values more than one signify over-representation and values less than one signify under-representation. Source: PLFS 2025

3 Upper castes also perform well in getting quality jobs both in government and private sector

A basic social disaggregation of jobs data makes this clear. If one were to look at relative share in best quality and worst-quality government and private salaried jobs, the basic social hierarchy remains intact. Non-SC-ST-OBC workers have a larger relative in share in best quality jobs – which offer a written contract, paid leaves or social security – in both government and private sector and the lowest relative share in worst quality salaried jobs which offer none of these perks. On the other hand, SCs fare the worst on this count in both government and private jobs.

Share in best and worst salaried jobs relative to share in all salaried jobs

Ratio of social group's share in different kinds of salaried jobs and its share in all salaried jobs



Values more than one signify over-representation and values less than one signify under-representation. Source: PLFS 2025

Because the recent protests were triggered by paper leaks for medical entrance exams, they were seen as misappropriation of the cake itself rather than a skewed distribution of it in favour of one social group or another. This might explain its pan-caste appeal rather than the movement being antagonistic toward one social group or another. As the data above shows, when the issue at hand seems to be hurting everyone equally then Indian society and its youngest stakeholders are capable of burying their distributional hatchet – otherwise justified by objective data – to mount a wider challenge to the government. This is exactly what makes dissatisfaction around conduct of examinations a big threat to the government of the day: it can transcend both cynical and justified social fissures to show unprecedented momentum.

{ WORLD } KEIGO HIGASHINO

Best-selling Japanese writer of mystery novels dies at 68

Japanese mystery fiction author Keigo Higashino has died aged 68, his publisher said on Monday, triggering an outpouring of grief among fans across Asia. Since his 1985 debut, Higashino wrote more than 100 books, with his works translated and published in over 40 countries and territories, and widely adapted for film and television. Higashino, whose books include "The Devotion of Suspect X" and "Malice", enjoyed a loyal following around Asia, including in China where thousands of people took to social media to mourn the writer. →PTI

COMMONWEALTH GAMES 2026

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

ATHLETICS

Men's 400m Round 1: Rajesh Ramesh, Vishal TK (4:30pm)

Women's high jump final Pooja Singh (11:35pm)

Men's 10,000m final Gulveer Singh (12:55am, Wed)

SWIMMING (HEATS)

Men's 50m butterfly Sajan Prakash (3:46pm)

Men's 100m backstroke: Srihari Nataraj (4:41pm)

Men's 50m freestyle S13: R Budigina, Imam Ali (4:57pm)

WEIGHTLIFTING

Women's 63kg: Nirupama Devi Seram (6:30pm)

Women's 69kg: Harjinder Kaur (11pm)

BOWLS

Men's pairs, Group B India vs Cook Islands (10:20pm)

Women's singles, Group C Nayanmoni Saikia vs Amy Williams, WAL (1:10am, Wed)

BOXING (QUARTER-FINALS)

Women's 54kg: Preeti Pawar vs Nicole Clyde (NIR)

Women's 60kg: Priya Ghanghas vs Niamh Mitchell, SCO (11pm)

Women's 65kg: Parveen Hooda vs Sacha Hickey, ENG, (11:30pm)

Men's 55kg: Jadumani Singh vs M Mwale, ZAM (12:15am, Wed)

Men's 90kg: Kapil Pokhariya vs R McNulty, SCO, (1:30am, Wed)

{ 'INTERVIEW } LORD GEORGE LEGGATT, UK SUPREME COURT JUDGE

'Indian Supreme Court's workload unsustainable in the long run'

Visiting India for the Singapore International Arbitration Centre (SIAC) annual conference, UK Supreme Court judge Lord George Leggatt spoke to **Utkarsh Anand** on the mounting docket of the Indian Supreme Court, judicial appointments, public confidence in courts in the social media age, live-streaming of proceedings, and the future of international arbitration. *Edited excerpts:*

The UK Supreme Court hears fewer than 100 appeals annually, while the Indian Supreme Court functions both as a constitutional court and as the country's final court of appeal, hearing tens of thousands of cases every year. If you were redesigning the institution today, would you separate its constitutional and appellate jurisdictions?

Let me first say that I have nothing but admiration, and in fact awe, for how hard the judges in India work. During this visit, I have been struck by the extraordinary workload they shoulder. I find it difficult to imagine having 60 cases listed in a day and having to prepare for all of them the previous night. Equally remarkable is a court that receives something like 90,000 cases in a single year.

By comparison, the UK Supreme Court, with about one-third the number of judges, deals with roughly 300 applications for permission to appeal annually and hears around 60 appeals, besides a similar number in the Judicial Committee of the Privy Council. The scale is simply incomparable.

It would be impertinent of me to tell India how it should organise its courts. But, speaking as a friend of the Indian judicial system, I think one observation is uncontroversial — the present position appears unsustainable in the longer term. India's economy is growing, people are becoming more aware of their rights and litigation is only likely to increase. You cannot simply solve the problem by appointing more judges to the Supreme Court. At some point there will have to be some form of reorganisation of the system. What that should look like is for India to decide, but it is notable that most other leading legal systems have a three-tier court structure, whereas the Indian Supreme Court also exercises original jurisdiction in addition to hearing appeals.

India and the UK follow very different systems for appointing judges. What, in your view, is the most important principle in preserving judicial independence while maintaining public confidence in the process?

I don't think there is a single ideal model because different constitutional systems evolve according to different national traditions. A process that works well in one country may not necessarily be appropriate in another, so I would not suggest that the UK's system should be replicated elsewhere.

The one principle I regard as fundamental is that political appointment of judges must be avoided. Judicial independence depends upon the judiciary remaining free from influence by the elected branches of government. That is essential to the rule of law.

In the UK, an independent appointments process is itself a relatively recent development and even that has, at times, faced possible political pressures. I also think judges should have a significant role in selecting judges for the higher courts because they read the judgments of judges serving below them and are often in the best position to assess their ability and temperament. Beyond that, I would not presume to comment on how the Indian system ought to function.

Courts across the world are increasingly operating in an age of social media, instant commentary and political polarisation. What do you see as the biggest challenge to maintaining public confidence in the judiciary?

The challenge is that we now live in an age of instant messaging, sound bites and very short attention spans. Judicial decisions are often complex, but reporting increasingly seeks to reduce them to a single takeaway. Inevitably, that can oversimplify and sometimes even distort what the court has actually decided.

This is not an Indian problem; it is something judges in many countries discuss. We cannot ignore it or pretend it doesn't exist. Courts need to engage with the public as effectively as they can.

In the UK Supreme Court, every judgment is accompanied by a short press summary written in plain language explaining the issues and the decision. The judge who authors the judgment also records a brief video explanation, which is made publicly available and is often used by broadcasters. We also have a press office that assists journalists seeking to understand judgments. These are all ways in which courts can help ensure that reporting is accurate and balanced, particularly when journalists may not have had sufficient time to read lengthy judgments in full.

In your dissent in Shvidler Vs Secretary of State (2025), you held that sanctions against Eugene Shvidler disproportionately interfered with his rights. At a time when national security increasingly shapes public law, where should courts draw the line between judicial deference and meaningful scrutiny of executive action?

There is no formula or easy rule for drawing that line, otherwise judges would not disagree. To my mind, the starting point is that judgments about national security and matters of national importance are principally the province of the elected branches of government. But the judicial function is to protect the fundamental rights of individuals.

When the collective will comes into conflict with individual rights, you need an independent and impartial arbiter. At what point those rights are being encroached upon disproportionately is an evaluative judgment each judge must make according to their own conscience. In Shvidler I dissented because — unlike the majority of the court — I thought that the reasons given by the government did not begin to justify the drastic curtailment of Mr Shvidler's liberty involved in freezing all his assets indefinitely.

As someone who has worked extensively in arbitration before joining the bench, what do you think is the biggest challenge facing international arbitration today?

I should begin by saying that my experience of arbitration has changed. Before becoming a judge in 2012, I regularly appeared as counsel and also sat as an arbitrator. Since joining the bench, my involvement has been indirect, dealing only with court challenges arising out of arbitral proceedings.

Even so, one concern has remained with me. Arbitration is supposed to offer a process that is quicker, simpler and cheaper than litigation. Too often, however, it ends up replicating the very defects of court proceedings. Arbitrations can become highly complex, extremely expensive and almost as slow as litigation itself.

If arbitration is to retain the confidence of the business community and fulfil its promise as an effective alternative to court litigation, it must find ways of delivering the efficiency that parties expect when they choose arbitration in the first place.

{ UKRAINIAN ATTACK ON SHIP }

Govt summons envoy over death of seafarer

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NEW DELHI: India on Monday summoned Ukrainian ambassador Oleksandr Polishchuk to lodge a strong protest over the death of an Indian seafarer in a Ukrainian attack on a merchant vessel in Russian waters, with the external affairs ministry condemning such strikes and highlighting their adverse impact on freedom of navigation and global commerce.

Chief officer Sagar Gupta, one of three Indian seafarers aboard the Marshall Islands-flagged MV Omorfi, was killed when the bulk carrier was hit by two drones in Russian territorial waters while transiting the Black Sea on July 18. India had already condemned the attack last week and reiterated its call to uphold international obligations for the safety and security of maritime navigation.

The external affairs ministry said Polishchuk was summoned in connection with the attack on MV Omorfi, which resulted in the "tragic death" of an Indian national. "The ministry conveyed its serious concern over the incident and condemned such attacks on commercial shipping in the strongest terms, underscoring their adverse impact on the safety of maritime navigation, freedom of navigation, and international commerce," it said in a statement.

Polishchuk was requested to convey to Ukrainian authorities "India's strong concerns over the targeting of commercial vessels". The ministry said "such actions, which endanger the lives of innocent civilian seafarers, are unacceptable and must be avoided".

The summoning of the Ukrainian ambassador follows similar actions against senior diplomats of Iran, the US and Russia in recent weeks over attacks against merchant vessels with Indian crew members in the Strait of Hormuz and the Black Sea.

Misri meets Chinese officials, discusses ties

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Vikram Misri

NEW DELHI: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri met top Chinese officials in Beijing on Monday as part of efforts by the two countries to normalise their relations, including maintaining peace and tranquillity on the border and addressing priority issues.

Misri's visit to China follows a meeting between external affairs minister S Jaishankar and his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi on July 22 on the margins of Asean-related meetings in the Philippines. Jaishankar emphasised peace and tranquillity in the border areas as a prerequisite for normal ties, and raised New Delhi's concerns about fair access to Chinese markets, balanced trade and predictability of supply chains.

Both sides "acknowledged the importance of maintaining peace and tranquillity in the India-China border areas" when Misri met vice minister of foreign affairs Hua Chunying, the Indian embassy said on social media.

Misri began his visit with a meeting with Sun Haiyan, vice minister of the international department of the central committee of the Communist Party of China, that focused on priority issues. They discussed ways to deepen the implementation of the guidance of Modi and Xi for bilateral relations, including "addressing issues of priority to both sides and by promoting political, people-to-people, academic and think-tank exchanges", the Indian embassy said.

Misri also met Hong Liang, deputy secretary general of the national committee of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference and discussed ways to enhance bilateral exchanges at the political and people-to-people levels.

Cabinet expansion decision to wrap up this week, says CM

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BENGALURU: Karnataka's prolonged wait for a cabinet expansion entered what Congress leaders described as its final phase on Monday, with chief minister DK Shivakumar travelling to New Delhi for talks expected to settle the composition of his ministry after weeks of internal consultations.

Before leaving Bengaluru, Shivakumar indicated that the exercise could be completed within days. "The media is in a hurry. I think within this week, I will complete the entire exercise," he said.

According to party leaders, Shivakumar will meet Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and other senior leaders during the visit. Former chief minister Siddaramaiah and Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee president BK Hariprasad are also expected to join the discussions, which follow an earlier round of consultations already held with the party leadership.

CM DK Shivakumar in a meeting with Union ministers and state MPs at Karnataka Bhavan in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

Deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said the final decision rested entirely with the Congress high command. "The CM, the party president, and former chief minister are in Delhi. They will discuss the matter with the party high command. The Cabinet expansion will happen only if the high command takes a decision. We are now heading to Delhi, and the outcome will be known after those discussions," he said.

The negotiations come as legislators seeking ministerial berths have converged on the national capital while the party weighs competing claims for the remaining vacancies. Party leaders said the leadership must balance regional and caste representation while accommodating numerous aspirants within the limited number of cabinet positions.

Congress MLA Santosh Lad said the process would follow the party's established decision making mechanism. "There is an established procedure, and everyone is aware of it. Both the deputy chief minister and the chief minister will go to Delhi, meet the party high command, and discuss the matter. This is a routine process that we follow," he said. Lad said Kharge, AICC general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala and AICC general secretary KC Venugopal would be part of the deliberations "Ultimately, the party high command will take the final decision," he said.

Commenting on the party's future leadership, Lad said Congress would seek to maintain continuity while creating opportunities for younger leaders. "As for senior leaders, they have devoted so much of their lives to public service and have done commendable work. I respect whatever decision they take. Personally, however, I feel they should continue to contest elections."

"Every party, including ours, wants to give opportunities to the younger generation while also maintaining a balance with experienced leaders. The high command will take that decision. We have to ensure a proper balance. The future leadership of the state will also emerge in due course," he said.

"There is no question of anyone needing a 'gate pass' or being forced out. As long as they are active, they remain our leaders. They have worked for the people of the state, especially for backward, oppressed and marginalised communities. We respect their service and leadership," Shivakumar took oath as chief minister on June 3 with a council of 13 ministers after Siddaramaiah resigned on May 28. Karnataka can have a ministry of up to 34 members, leaving 20 cabinet positions yet to be filled.

beloved bangalore

Sakleshpur's poet-saint and his jolige of song

Roopa Pai

July marks the passing of two legendary personalities associated with Karnataka and Kannada. Neither spoke Kannada as a mother tongue, but both received the Rajyotsava Award to mark an immense contribution to the language and culture. One of them was the silver-voiced playback singer, *Gaana Kogile* S Janaki, who died at 88 in Mysuru on July 11. The other was towering folklorist and Gandhian, *Kannada Santha* (the Kannada saint) Dr SK Karim Khan, who died in Bengaluru on July 29, 2006. The arcs of these two remarkable lives met briefly but memorably.

Recording her first song for a Tamil film at 19, Janaki went on to a dazzling musical career spanning six decades, during which she garnered credits on a staggering 48,000 songs in 20 Indian languages, of which the largest number – over 8000! – were in Kannada. Many of them were much-loved duets with greats like PB Srinivas, SP Balasubrahmanyam and Dr Rajkumar. Originally from Andhra Pradesh, she chose to move to Mysore at the age of 80, and lived there happily for the rest of her life.

Unlike Janaki, Dr SK Karim Khan was born in the coffee-growing hills of Sakleshpur in 1912. His father, Abdul Rahman Khan, was a decorated Afghan soldier who had fought against the British in the Second Anglo-Afghan War; his mother, Zainabi, was of Arab descent. Young Karim attended the local Kannada medium school, where he mingled with children from various communities. One of his teachers, the Sanskrit scholar Achangi Narayana Shastri, was a huge influence on the boy. Before long, Karim developed a keen interest in Sanskrit, Kannada literature, and Indian philosophical traditions and texts.

But it was *Janapada* – the folk traditions – that truly captured Karim's imagination. As a lad, he was often to be found at the campfires of itinerant traders passing through Hassan and Sakleshpur, listening, enthralled, to their songs. That early love would later lead him on a 30-year-long independent project, mostly on foot, through villages, hills, and forests, documenting the oral lore, songs and stories of both rural communities and the far more remote tribal communities of Karnataka – the *Halakkis, Kadukurubas, Siddis, Eravas, Soligas* and more. His extraordinary effort impoverished him, but also earned him the reverential title of *Janapada Jangama*, and saw him appointed to the post of President of the Karnataka Janapada Academy in 1987, at the age of 75. During his three-year tenure, he initiated the first-ever comprehensive video documentation of a variety of folk performing arts and culturally important jaatres (temple fairs) across the state.

When he was only 24, Karim attended Gandhiji's 1936 speech about Swaraj at the National High School, Bangalore. Mesmerised, he donned the Gandhi cap, embraced khadi for life, and plunged into the freedom struggle, writing poems and stories about Hindu-Muslim unity. Using his beautiful singing voice to advantage, he sang both original and learnt songs to recruit people to the Indian National Congress, and was jailed several times for his pains. Alongside this, he was deeply involved in the movement for the unification of Karnataka.

His extensive knowledge of Kannada dialects and folk traditions also saw filmmakers woo him to write screenplays, dialogues and song lyrics for them. Among his most memorable compositions are *Baara Chandramaa, Neene Neere Mandaara* and the timeless devotional *Jaya Gowri Jagadeeshwari* – all of which were sung, as a solo or duet, by – drumroll, please– S Janaki.

Tragically, in his final years, Dr SK Karim Khan was forgotten by the government of his home state. In 2014, following relentless advocacy by his family and fans, the Kannada Santha had a main street in Bangalore's upscale Indiranagar named after him, a street that both residents and cabbies continue to refer to as 100 Feet Road.

(Roopa Pai is a writer who has carried on a longtime love affair with her hometown Bengaluru)

HC refuses to halt probe on fake certificate row

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka High Court on Monday refused to halt a criminal investigation against the daughter of suspended former Karnataka Public Service Commission chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar, with the petitioner withdrawing her plea after the court questioned the legitimacy of an income certificate allegedly used to claim reservation benefits in a government recruitment process. Hearing a petition filed by Suma S Sahukar seeking to quash the first information report against her, Justice M Nagaprasanna said the allegations disclosed a prima facie case warranting investigation and indicated that the court would not invoke its inherent powers to terminate the proceedings at the threshold.

During the hearing, the judge repeatedly questioned how the petitioner could claim reservation by declaring an annual income of Rs 40,000 when investigators alleged her family's annual income was about Rs 30 lakh. "Prima facie, this appears to be a case of fraud," Justice Nagaprasanna observed.

THE JUDGE QUESTIONED HOW THE PETITIONER COULD CLAIM QUOTA WHEN INVESTIGATORS ALLEGED HER FAMILY'S ANNUAL INCOME WAS ABOUT ₹30 LAKH

"You have taken away the opportunity meant for a poor candidate. Is this how reservation benefits are to be claimed?" the court asked. The petitioner's counsel argued that Suma Sahukar had disclosed only her individual income and that no criminal offence was made out. The defence maintained that the dispute centred on the interpretation of the income criteria and therefore did not warrant criminal prosecution.

The court rejected that argument, observing that the certificate in question required disclosure of the annual family income rather than the applicant's personal earnings alone.

"Can you ignore the family income when the certificate itself requires disclosure of the family's annual income? How can such a claim be justified?" the judge asked.

Justice Nagaprasanna also expressed concern over repeated controversies surrounding recruitments conducted by the Karnataka Public Service Commission. "Every recruitment by the KPSC appears to end up in controversy. This is becoming a disturbing pattern," the judge remarked. With the court indicating that it would neither quash the proceedings nor grant interim protection, the petitioner's counsel sought permission to withdraw the plea. The High Court dismissed the petition as withdrawn, allowing the criminal investigation to continue. The case centres on allegations that Suma Sahukar submitted a false income certificate while applying under a reserved category in a government recruitment process.

Investigators allege that although the family's annual income was around ₹30 lakh, the application was supported by a certificate declaring an annual income of only ₹40,000, enabling her to claim reservation benefits meant for economically eligible candidates.

Cong supports FIR on Khalid's poster

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BENGALURU: Congress leaders on Monday defended the registration of an FIR over posters supporting Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam displayed during a NEET protest in Bengaluru, even as they reiterated their questions over the prolonged legal proceedings against Khalid.

Upparpet Police registered the case against an unidentified woman after a woman police officer deployed on security duty at Freedom Park alleged that the protester displayed placards supporting Khalid and Imam, both facing prosecution in connection with the 2020 northeast Delhi riots case.

Police personnel removed the placards at the venue to prevent any disturbance. Several participants in the protest reportedly distanced themselves from the display and asked the woman to leave. Officers later examined photographs, videos and witness statements before registering the FIR under provisions relating to acts allegedly intended to provoke unrest.

Investigators are now examining whether the placards were prepared independently or supplied by an organisation.

Home minister Priyank Kharge said the investigation would proceed independently and that the government would not interfere. Earlier on July 25, Kharge had questioned why Khalid's trial had not begun despite six years having passed since his arrest. Karnataka BJP president BY Vijayendra welcomed the police action and called for a probe to determine if the display of the posters was part of a larger organised effort.

Crackdown on mosquitoes

A municipal worker carries out fumigation in a park to curb the spread of mosquitoes in Bengaluru on Monday. PTI

Min: Govt has ₹341 cr to ensure water supply

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BENGALURU: Karnataka minister Eshwar Khandre on Monday said that the state has ₹341 crore available to ensure drinking water supply and there is no shortage of funds to meet this requirement, amid the drought situation.

He also directed officials to drill new borewells only in cases of absolute necessity.

Speaking to reporters, Khandre said ₹117 crore had already been released in advance for rural drinking water supply, and the chief minister had also announced ₹1 crore for each Assembly constituency to support drinking water projects, ensuring adequate financial resources. The minister said officials have been instructed to ensure uninterrupted drinking water supply in Gram Panchayat areas where traditional water sources had dried up.

"They have been directed to identify alternative water sources, hire private borewells or open wells wherever necessary, conduct water quality tests and supply drinking water through tankers," he added. Khandre, who holds Rural Development and Panchayat Raj portfolios, said officials should be sensitive to the hardship faced by people and discharge their responsibilities accordingly.

Asserting that there is no need for people to migrate amid drought situation, as there is work for hands willing to work, the minister said, there is no shortage of funds under the new rural employment guarantee scheme.

CENTRE'S REPLY ON MEKEDATU ROW BACKED K'TAKA'S STANCE: GOVT

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government on Monday pointed to a written reply from the Union ministry of Jal Shakti in Parliament, saying it reinforced the state's position that the proposed Mekedatu balancing reservoir does not require the consent of Tamil Nadu, Kerala or Puducherry.

The clarification, issued in response to a Rajya Sabha question from Tamil Nadu MP Anbumani Ramadoss, was circulated by the chief minister's office even as chief minister DK Shivakumar travelled to New Delhi to press Karnataka's case on interstate river projects, including Mekedatu. In his written reply, minister of state for jal shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary said the Supreme Court's February 16, 2018 judgment on the Cauvery water dispute did not require Karnataka to obtain the approval of downstream riparian states before constructing a structure across the Cauvery.

The minister also cited the Supreme Court's reaffirmation of Clause XVIII of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal award, which states: "Nothing in the order of this Tribunal shall impair the right or power or authority of any state to regulate within its boundaries the use of water or to enjoy the benefit of waters within that state in a manner not inconsistent with the order of this Tribunal." The parliamentary reply, however, also said Karnataka's detailed project report for the Mekedatu Reservoir, submitted in 2019, had been returned for revision.

The parents found the boy in a water filled pit dug by the railway department on Sunday. HT

8-year-old falls into water-filled rly pit in Raichur, dies: Police

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BIDAR : An eight-year-old boy drowned after slipping into a water filled pit dug for a railway construction project in Karnataka's Raichur district on Sunday, police said.

The child had accompanied his parents to their agricultural land near Kapagal village in Manvi taluk when he wandered off while playing. His parents later found him in a pit, about 9 to 10 feet deep, that had been excavated for a railway column and had filled with water, according to the police.

"An incident occurred near Kapagal village in Manvi taluk at around 10.30 am on Sunday. The parents found the boy in a water filled pit dug by the Railway Department at Survey No. 223, adjacent to their land," Manvi police inspector Somashekar Kencha Reddy told HT. The child's family has accused the railway authorities, the contractor and engineers of failing to secure the excavation site. Manvi MLA G Hampayya Nayak said action would be taken against those responsible for the construction work. "Instructions have been issued to the concerned authorities, and action will be taken against the contractor and the engineer responsible. Compensation will also be provided by the government to the deceased child's family," he said.

"Similar unsecured pits have been dug at several railway construction sites across the district, but proper safety arrangements have not been been made," social activist Shivkumar Kamthane Sindol said.

Raichur deputy commissioner Poovitha S said an inquiry was already underway and that district authorities had recently instructed railway officials to strengthen safety measures. "An FIR has already been filed regarding the incident. Regarding the railway project, instructions were given to the railway authorities last week to put up fencing and notices about the works being carried out," she said.

Cong faces no Siddaramaiah test in 2028 polls

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BENGALURU: The Congress has weathered the transition from Siddaramaiah to D K Shivakumar in government. The party is yet to face a difficult transition in the next assembly election, when Karnataka voters will see Siddaramaiah absent from the ballot for the first time in decades, political analysts said.

By announcing that he will not contest the 2028 assembly elections, Siddaramaiah has done more than signal the end of his electoral career. He has set the stage for the Congress's first real test of whether the political coalition he assembled can endure without its principal architect seeking a mandate himself.

His son and Karnataka minister Yathindra Siddaramaiah said there was no question of asking his father to reconsider the decision.

"As his son, I would never ask him to return to electoral politics. He is nearing 80, and at this stage I want him to have the rest and medical care he deserves. His well-being matters far more to me than another election," he said.

Siddaramaiah

"Once my father reaches a decision, he rarely changes it. He had spoken earlier about stepping away from elections, and he has now repeated that position," he added.

For nearly two decades, Siddaramaiah has been more than the party's tallest leader in Karnataka.

He has served as the Congress's principal campaigner, its most recognisable mass leader and the face of the AHINDA coalition of minorities, backward classes and Dalits.

SIDDARAMAIAH'S ANNOUNCEMENT TO NOT CONTEST THE 2028 POLLS MORE THAN SIGNALLED THE END OF HIS ELECTORAL CAREER

While DK Shivakumar now leads the government, the Congress has yet to demonstrate that Siddaramaiah's electoral appeal can be transferred to another leader.

That question becomes even more pressing because Siddaramaiah's influence extends beyond public popularity.

He continues to enjoy the backing of a sizeable group of legislators and remains central to decisions affecting the party organisation. His decision to stay in Karnataka rather than pursue national politics means that influence is unlikely to disappear after 2028.

Yet influence without electoral participation presents a different political equation.

Journalist and political analyst Sugata Srinivasaraju said Siddaramaiah was unlikely to shift his attention to Delhi.

"He has never shown much interest in moving to national politics, largely because language has always been a limitation. I expect him to remain an influential presence in the Assembly, but I don't see him taking an active role in preparing the party for the 2028 campaign," he said.

Srinivasaraju also said Siddaramaiah's role outside government had often reshaped Karnataka's politics. "Looking back over three decades, one pattern stands out. Siddaramaiah has usually been most engaged when he has a direct stake in power. When he has been outside government, his interventions have often unsettled the political establishment. The 2018 coalition period is frequently cited as an example," he said.

Some within the Congress believe the transition can be managed because the party, and not just Siddaramaiah alone, commands loyalty among large sections of the AHINDA coalition.

Political commentator A Narayana argued that Dalits and minorities have historically voted for the Congress as much as for Siddaramaiah. "The AHINDA coalition is not politically homogeneous. Dalits and minorities have traditionally identified more with the Congress than with any one leader. Among OBC communities, Siddaramaiah's strongest support has come from the Kurubas. His departure could even give the Congress an opportunity to rebuild support among other backward communities that have drifted away," he said.

"The party insists Siddaramaiah will continue to play an active political role even after he stops contesting elections. But campaigning for a party and standing before voters are different forms of political authority," summarised a leader who didn't want to be named.

SOUTH REGION

HC quashes Tamil Nadu's job grant to stampede victims' kin

Ayesha Arvind
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BENGALURU: The Madras high court on Monday struck down a Government Order issued by the Tamil Nadu government granting compassionate appointments to the families of 41 people who died in the Karur stampede last September, holding that the decision violated Articles 14 and 16 of the Constitution and would open the "floodgates" for similar claims arising out of other tragedies.

A bench of justices CV Karthikeyan and R Sakthivel said public employment cannot become a form of compensation outside the constitutional framework governing appointments. If the government extended jobs in one tragedy, it would become difficult to deny similar relief in other cases, the bench said.

"Public employment is not to be thrown away by the State. It has to be earned. Its value has to be realised. Its importance is to be cherished. There are many who wait seeking employment," the high court said.

The court noted that thousands of eligible applicants already waited for compassionate appointments under the existing scheme. The state cannot overlook their claims and create a separate class of beneficiaries through an executive order, it said.

The court added that the government should instead have funded "technical education, skill development, and entrepreneurship programmes" for eligible members of the affected families.

"We wonder why the government could not have extended training in skills and entrepreneurship for deserving members of families. The government would be creating leaders, entrepreneurs, self-sufficient individuals in each family who can later provide employment to others. The government can bear the expense of such technical courses," the high court said.

The stampede killed 41 people in Karur on Sept 25, 2025.

The high court acknowledged that it had not heard the beneficiaries before striking down the appointments. However, it noted that its July 10 interim order had made the appointments subject to judicial review. The beneficiaries had therefore accepted the appointments knowing the court could set them aside.

The court passed its order on a public interest litigation filed by Madurai-based advocate Theeran Thirumurugan challenging the validity of the GO.

The petitioner had argued that compassionate appointments must conform to Articles 14 and 16 of the Constitution and follow the existing government scheme. He said the state had failed to explain how the Karur stampede justified a departure from the established policy.

Advocate general Vijay Narayan, who appeared for the state government, defended the decision and said the GO had been notified as an "exceptional measure" under Article 162 of the Constitution, which pertains to the executive power of the state.

The AG argued that the victims formed a "distinct class" deserving rehabilitation "beyond monetary compensation" and said the government had only offered entry-level posts to provide long-term financial security to bereaved families.

On July 10, the same bench had allowed the state to proceed with the appointments but made them temporary and subject to judicial review. During that hearing, the judges had observed that the Karur stampede did not involve any police excess or direct wrongdoing by the state for which it needed to announce jobs. The bench had also sought details from the Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission on the norms governing compassionate appointments before taking up the challenge on merits.

Montek Singh Ahluwalia

MS AHLUWALIA TO HEAD TN REVENUE AUGMENTATION PANEL, SAYS GOVT

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Monday formed a devenue Augmentation Committee chaired by noted economist and former deputy chairman of Union Planning Commission and former Member of Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister, Montek Singh Ahluwalia.

The committee's formation comes in the backdrop of the White Paper released in June 2026 which set a roadmap for better revenue mobilisation and administrative reforms and had also observed a decline in Goods and Services Tax, Value Added Tax, excise and revenues from mines and minerals.

Sharing some of the highlights on the fiscal condition, the government order said the State Own Tax Revenue (SOTR) to Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) ratio fell to 5.45% in 2025-26, the lowest in 20 years.

The decline in the state's tax revenue amounts to about ₹1.23 lakh crore of annual revenue foregone, roughly 90% of the fiscal deficit in 2025-26.

Noting that the states like Maharashtra, Karnataka have shown growth in SOTR-GSDP ratio and Tamil Nadu alone has registered a steady decline, the order said there is a need to align the growth of revenue in sync with the growth in the economy and to augment and sustain the resource base.

It said the committee would suggest steps to sustainably augment the state's tax and non-tax revenues, rationalise rates, fees and exemptions, improving compliance, plug leakages and identify under-tapped resources

{ CONTEMPT OF COURT CASE }

Telangana HC orders Hydraa chief's removal

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana high court on Monday ordered the immediate removal of senior IPS officer AV Ranganath as commissioner of the Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (Hydraa), holding him guilty of repeatedly committing contempt of court by ignoring its directions, people familiar with the matter said.

Hearing a contempt petition related to a 40-acre land dispute at Lothkunta in Secunderabad involving a private construction company, Justice Anil Kumar Jukanti directed chief secretary Sanjay Aju to identify a suitable officer to replace Ranganath as Hydraa commissioner.

Hydraa is an agency constituted by the state government in July 2024 to protect lakes and government land from encroachments.

The petitioner alleged that Hydraab officials entered the disputed property despite subsisting judicial restraint orders, amounting to wilful disobedience of the court's earlier directions.

Observing that the Hydraa commissioner had repeatedly failed to comply with court orders, Justice Jukanti remarked that Ranganath had become "a law unto himself."

The judge also noted that 63 contempt cases were reportedly pending against Ranganath before the high court during his tenure as Hydraa commissioner. The bench described the situation as a matter of grave concern, saying it reflected a pattern of disregard for judicial directives.

Justice Jukanti further observed that Hydraa, despite having no statutory powers, was superseding government departments, which were increasingly approaching the agency instead

AV Ranganath

of exercising their own statutory authority.

The court had earlier directed Ranganath to appear in person and submit an unconditional written apology through an affidavit by Monday. However, he did not appear before the court, and his counsel informed the bench that they intended to file a petition instead of the affidavit.

Taking serious exception to his absence, the judge viewed it as an act of wilful disobedience and directed the chief secretary to replace the present Hydraa commissioner with immediate effect.

Justice Jukanti stressed the need to appoint an officer who would ensure compliance with judicial orders and uphold the rule of law.

Last week, the high court directed the Indian Army to take Ranganath into custody and lodge him in an army barracks for repeatedly violating court orders. Meanwhile, an official familiar with the matter said the government was likely to approach a division bench to challenge the order.

Reacting to the high court order, Hydraa commissioner AV Ranganath said that he would contest all the contempt cases legally and expressed complete faith in the judiciary. He claimed that all the contempt cases against him were moved by influential land grabbers. "My only mistake is standing in the way of such alleged encroachments," he added.

Senior leader Varla Ramaiah is among the top contenders. HT

INTENSE LOBBYING WITHIN TDP FOR 2 GOVERNOR QUOTA COUNCIL SEATS

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HYDERABAD: Intense lobbying is underway in Andhra Pradesh 's ruling Telugu Desam Party (TDP) for the two state legislative council seats under the Governor's quota set to fall vacant on Tuesday, a party functionary said.

The terms of state legislative council deputy chairman Zakia Khanam and YSR Congress Party MLC Pandula Ravindra Babu, both nominated under the Governor's quota, are set to end on Tuesday.

The party functionary said the TDP leadership has begun deliberations on suitable nominees. Among the names reportedly under consideration is senior TDP leader Varla Ramaiah, who has twice aspired for a Rajya Sabha berth but narrowly missed out both times. "The party is likely to accommodate him through the Governor's nominated quota in the legislative council," said the functionary.

For the second seat, the party is considering a strong leader from the Rayalaseema region as part of the party's regional balancing strategy. Among the contenders at the forefront are Reddappagari Srinivas Reddy, Tippe Swamy, Prabhakar Chowdary and B Tech Ravi, added the functionary.

"The final decision rests with the TDP leadership, which is expected to weigh political, regional and social equations before announcing its nominees," the party functionary quoted above said.

T'gana: Police launch search for IPS trainee officer accused in sexual harassment case

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HYDERABAD: Telangana police have launched a manhunt for trainee IPS officer Mulagani Uday Krishna Reddy after the high court refused him interim protection from arrest in a sexual harassment case involving a fellow trainee IPS officer.

Police said Reddy was untraceable at both addresses mentioned in his petition. The probe is now being conducted by inspector Jyothsna, who will work under the supervision of SHE Teams DCP Lavanya Naik Jadhav.

Jadhav recorded the statement of the woman trainee IPS officer, who lodged the complaint, in the presence of senior police and academy officials.

POLICE SAID REDDY WAS UNTRACEABLE AT BOTH ADDRESSES MENTIONED IN HIS PETITION FOR INTERIM RELIEF FROM ARREST

According to a senior police official, Uday Krishna Reddy could not be traced at both the locations, addresses of which he had mentioned in his petition filed in the high court on July 22, seeking quashing of the case against him.

"The police who went to serve notices to him for questioning could not find him at any of the two addresses. Even his phone remains switched off," the official said, adding a manhunt was launched to trace his whereabouts.

On July 19, a criminal case was registered against Reddy at the Attapur police station under various sections based on the complaint given by the 30-year-old trainee woman IPS officer.

The police booked him under sections 74 (assault or criminal force to a woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 75 (sexual harassment), 77 (voyeurism), 78 (stalking), 79 (word, gesture or act intended to insult the modesty of a woman), 127(2) (wrongful confinement), 115(2) (voluntarily causing hurt) and 351(2) (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), along with sections 66E (violation of privacy) and 67A (publishing or transmitting material containing a sexually explicit act) of the IT Act, 2000.

At the same time, based on the prima facie evidence, the Sardar Vallabhbhai National Police Academy also suspended him from training.

A day after the case was registered, Uday consumed excessive liquor and lost consciousness. Suspecting a suicide attempt, his brother and friends shifted him to a nearby hospital, from where he was discharged two days later.

JanaSena Party likely to seek higher seat share in local polls

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HYDERABAD: As Andhra Pradesh gears up for the local body elections, most likely in September, the JanaSena Party is seeking a larger share in the seats compared to what it was allotted in the last general elections in 2024, people familiar with the matter said.

Though no official talks have begun among the alliance partners on the seat-sharing formula, pressure is mounting on Jana Sena Party chief and deputy chief minister Pawan Kalyan from the party's grassroots leadership to demand a larger share in the number of seats in the local body elections.

"There were reports that TDP working president and state IT minister Nara Lokesh told his party leaders at a recent meeting that seats in the local body elections could be shared among the alliance partners in 80:15:5 ratio, with the TDP contesting 80% of seats, JanaSena Party 15% and the BJP the remaining 5%. This has caused a lot of commotion in our party," said a senior JanaSena Party functionary, who refused to be named.

Nadendla Manohar

Last week, JanaSena Party political affairs committee (PAC) chairman and state civil supplies minister Nadendla Manohar sought to dispel the apprehensions that the party was under pressure to accept the TDP's seat sharing formula.

Manohar categorically stated that the seat-sharing arrangement done during the 2024 assembly election cannot be accepted in the local body elections. "Seat-sharing will depend on where JanaSena has organisational strength, strong leadership and winning prospects," he said at Tenali last Friday.

During the 2024 general elections, the TDP contested 144 out of 175 assembly seats in the state, leaving 21 seats to JanaSena Party and 10 seats to the BJP. In the Lok Sabha elections, the TDP contested 17 out of 25 MP seats, leaving two seats to JanaSena Party and six to the BJP.

Despite being confined to a few seats, the JanaSena Party achieved 100% strike rate by winning all the 21 assembly seats and two Lok Sabha seats.

Manohar reminded party workers that Kalyan had voluntarily accepted a smaller share of assembly seats to prevent the anti-YSRCP vote from splitting and to ensure the NDA's victory.

He said in the last two years, the party has grown across the state, adding that discussions had already begun within the NDA coordination committee.

The TDP, however, has chosen to react cautiously. "The party leadership has given strict instructions to all its leaders and cadre at all levels not to jump to any conclusions and make any statements on the seat-sharing among the alliance partners. The decision will be taken at the highest level at an appropriate time," TDP's N Vijay Kumar said.

Udhayanidhi meets imprisoned DMK MLA; hits out at TN govt

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TIRUNELVELI: Leader of the Opposition in the Tamil Nadu Assembly Udhayanidhi Stalin on Monday slammed the state government for arresting DMK MLA G V Markandeyan, after meeting the legislator at the Palayamkottai Central Prison.

"Filing unnecessary and false cases against those expressing their opinions on social media, as well as office-bearers of opposition parties, seems to be the sole work of this government," Udhyanidhi said.

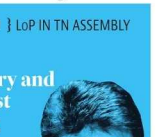
The senior DMK leader, who interacted with Markandeyan for about 30 minutes earlier in the day, said he assured him that the DMK high command would provide all necessary legal assistance.

"Along with former Speaker Appavu, Geetha Jeevan, and Anitha Radhakrishnan, I met our Vilathikulam MLA, dear brother Markandeyan, to inquire about his health. He is doing very well," he added.

Markandeyan was arrested in Tuticorin following a police complaint that he made defamatory and threatening remarks against Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay during a public meeting in Kovilpatti.

{ UDHAYANIDHI STALIN } LoP IN TN ASSEMBLY

Filing unnecessary and false cases against those expressing their opinions... seems to be the sole work of this govt



The DMK legislator was arrested for his purported "we will crush your bones" remark, allegedly made against chief minister and TVK chief C Joseph Vijay.

Speaking to reporters, Udhyanidhi hit out at the government, accusing it of resorting to arrests and filing cases against opposition MLAs. The DMK has described the police action as a campaign of political vendetta by the TVK-led government, while the ruling party maintained the arrest followed due legal process.

On his party's resilience against political pressure, the Leader of Opposition said, "DMK is a movement that has faced far greater repression than this."Over 200 party workers gathered outside the prison premises during his visit.

HT

Toll in firecracker unit blast in TN rises to 3: Officials

SIVAKASI: The toll in the blast at an illegal fireworks manufacturing unit near Sivakasi on Sunday rose to three on Monday, officials said, adding that relief operations were still underway. The injured co-owner of the site, identified as R Ramachandran (40), who was admitted at the Virudhunagar Government Medical College Hospital in critical condition with 60 per cent burns on July 26, succumbed to his injuries on Monday

Co-operative bank manager dies by suicide

KOZHIKODE: A cooperative bank manager and local CPI(M) leader allegedly died by suicide inside a public library near his house at Mokeri in Kozhikode district on Monday, police said, adding that they suspected personal issues to have led to the incident. The body was sent for post-mortem examination and a case of unnatural death has been registered, said officers, adding that the deceased held office-bearer positions in the party earlier but was relieved after the assembly elections.

Techie booked for molesting Dutch woman in Hyd

HYDERABAD: A 36-year-old woman from the Netherlands has accused a software engineer of sexually harassing her, following which a case was registered , police said on Monday. The incident allegedly occurred in March when the woman visited her boyfriend in the city , said an officer, adding that a probe into the matter was currently underway.

Man succumbs to brain fever in Kerala

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KOZHIKODE: A 49-year-old man undergoing treatment for amoebic meningoencephalitis died at the Government Medical College Hospital in Kozhikode on Monday, health officials said.

The deceased was identified as Biju, an autorickshaw driver and a native of Naderi in Koyilandy. According to Health officials, Biju was diagnosed with amoebic meningoencephalitis, commonly known as brain fever, on July 23.

Officials said Biju's condition deteriorated on Monday and he succumbed to the infection while undergoing treatment.

Health officials said efforts were underway to ascertain how he contracted the infection.

Amoebic meningoencephalitis is a rare but highly fatal infection of the central nervous system caused by free-living amoebae. The infection is typically contracted through exposure to contaminated freshwater sources such as lakes, rivers and streams.

ACCORDING TO DATA FROM THE DIRECTORATE OF HEALTH SERVICES, BIJU'S DEATH TOOK THE TOLL OF BRAIN FEVER DEATHS IN THE STATE THIS YEAR TO 41

According to data from the Directorate of Health Services (DHS), Kerala, 154 cases of brain fever had been reported in the state till July 25, with 40 deaths. With Biju's death, the toll has risen to 41. This month alone, 13 cases have been reported. Three patients had died before the latest fatality, taking the death toll for July to four.

Dhanush fan event bolsters political foray buzz

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CHENNAI: Ahead of popular Tamil actor Dhanush's 43rd birthday on Tuesday, a playground owned by a private college in Thiruvallur district wore a festive look on Sunday. The event was the latest in a series of public engagements that the actor's significant fanbase has cited to speculate on a potential foray into electoral politics.

Posters and flags emblazoned with the actor's smiling face embedded in a star lined the road leading to the venue, where thousands of fans waited for the actor, whose arrival while clad in a white shirt and dhoti heralded a wave of cheers.

The event was the result of a collaborative effort by Dhanush's numerous fan clubs across the state, said people aware of the matter. It featured blood donation camps, and an outreach program to distribute various kinds of welfare to people. Addressing the gathering, Dhanush appealed to the state government to step up its welfare outreach by addressing civic problems in a focused manner. He also exhorted his fans to utilise their collective for social work.

"So many of you have gathered here. You all are able to assemble together in one place. There is a power in that unity, in that oneness. You must lead that power in a positive direction. You must give that power a purpose,"he said.

"Rather than just meeting, taking photos, or seeing each other at an audio launches, all of you should come together and carry out many more good welfare initiatives. In your area, in your street, in your neighbour's house, in the house across from yours. If you understand what someone needs and join hands, you can achieve it," added the actor.

From AIADMK supremo MG Ramachandran, who began his public life as one of the enduring stars the state ever produced, DMK founder K Karunanidhi, who was one of the most sought-after screenplay writers of his time, to MGR's protege and former chief minister J Jayalalithaa, and finally, sitting chief minister C Joseph Vijay, whose Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) built on two decades of grassroots development among a spiderweb of fan clubs with numerous local chapters to pull of a stellar electoral performance in the recently concluded state assembly elections, Tamil Nadu's post-colonial politics has historically been associated closely with the state's homegrown film industry.

Dhanush

Certain fans of Dhanush who spoke to HT on condition of anonymity also ascribed significance to his attire at the event, which is synonymous with political leaders in the state. The recent launch of the *Akila Indhiya Dhanush Narpani Mandram*'s flag also spurred buzz about a political entry.

Political analyst Ramesh Sethuraman noted that Dhanush's fanbase boasted a significant strength of numbers in the state. However, as far as political aspirations were concerned, he offered a sceptical take. "The fans do not fall under the category of aspiring political followers and his cinema movies do not have political narratives. Also he has not expressed political aspirations in the public forum till date," Sethuraman told HT.

He also dismissed the possibility of Dhanush emerging as a political alternative to CM Vijay.

"Vijay's political entry has broken the spell of Dravidian parties and paved way for youth centric politics" he said.

Head of Annamalai University's political science department Dr P Sakthivel said that Dhanush was aware of his strengths and weaknesses in the film industry. He echoed the point that a foray into politics would need stronger groundwork and coordination. "As of now, the organisation and fans club should be more vibrant. One important reason he is not active in politics is that he has not spoken about any issues highly pertinent to the people of Tamil Nadu, whether they be education or water issues or centre state relations. He has not expressed a clear stand," he said.

Sakthivel, however, noted the role of social media and youth outreach.

"The Gen-Z population would judge his level of activity in the political realm, and whether he can deliver," he said.

Ram temple donation probe must be speedy, qualitative, impartial: SC

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NEW DEHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said it will take "remedial steps to ensure transparency" in the management of donations received at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, while making it clear that its immediate priority was to ensure a "speedy, qualitative and impartial investigation in a timebound manner" into allegations of embezzlement of donations.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, along with justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, also directed the Uttar Pradesh government to associate an expert in forensic audit with the newly constituted special investigation team (SIT), observing that the probe will necessarily involve scrutiny of financial accounts and transactions.

"The nature of investigation involves accounts...We are asking for a report. We are not closing the matter. We would like to know about the investigation. The rest we will decide at a later stage," observed the bench, while directing the SIT to submit a status report within two weeks.

The direction came after solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Uttar Pradesh government, informed the court that the state had constituted a four-member SIT headed by inspector general of Police Kiran S, in compliance with the court's previous observations. Mehta, assisted by senior additional advocate general Sharan Dev Singh Thakur, agreed to the court's suggestion that a member experienced in forensic audit be inducted into the investigation team. "The present focus is on investigation. We must have a speedy, qualitative and impartial investigation in a timebound manner," said the bench.

In its order, the court recorded that the state issued an office memorandum constituting the SIT comprising inspector general Kiran S, deputy inspector general

The SC said it will take steps to ensure transparency in the management of donations at the Ram temple.

Somen Barma, Ayodhya senior superintendent of police Gaurav Grover and additional superintendent of police Ritesh Kumar Singh. It further noted the solicitor general's statement that "a member having experience of forensic audit will also be associated as a member of the SIT."

During the hearing, senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for Rashtriya Janata Dal MP Sudhakar Singh, urged the court to strengthen transparency in the handling of donations by directing that details of contributions received by the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust be placed in the public domain.

"One of the issues would be whether the money sent by people reached the trust or not. People have given ₹500, ₹1,000. Ultimately, there are reports that the money has not reached the trust. Whatever the trust got may be shown on a website so that people will know their money has reached," Kamat submitted.

The bench, however, indicated that these issues will be examined as part of the ongoing investigation. "SIT will look into all aspects...all the remedial steps that need to be taken will be taken by us", said the bench, assuring that "remedial steps to ensure transparency" would follow.

Kamat also sought the appointment of a retired judge to monitor the probe. The plea was opposed by Mehta, who submitted that such a direction was unnecessary as the present bench was itself monitoring the investigation. The court did not pass any order on that request.

The development comes a week after the top court cautioned all parties against politicising the controversy while asking the state to consider placing the investigation under the supervision of the same senior officials who had conducted the preliminary inquiry into the alleged fraud. Acting on those observations, the Uttar Pradesh government on July 25 constituted the new SIT headed by IG Kiran S.

Custody of 8 accused extended till Aug 10

A special court in Ayodhya on Monday extended the judicial custody of all eight accused in the Ram temple donation theft case by 14 days, till August 10,. Special Judge (Anti-Corruption) Rajat Verma extended the judicial custody after they were produced before the court virtually from the district jail.

{ MANUAL SCAVENGING DEATHS }

SC issues contempt notices to 15 state chief secretaries

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday issued contempt notices to chief secretaries of 15 states, including Delhi, for their failure to prevent manual scavenging deaths despite a clear direction by the top court in a 2023 ruling to end such an inhuman practice.

The court passed the order on being told that after the October 20, 2023, order directing all states, Union territories and civic agencies to ensure no manual scavenging takes place, 100 deaths took place between 2024 and 2025, with unverified reports claiming that more than 100 sewer deaths have already taken place this year.

Referring to data forming part of the Centre's response given to a question raised in Parliament in March this year, a bench of justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi noted that 165 deaths were reported from 15 states, with 65 in 2023, 54 in 2024, and 46 in 2025. The bench said, "Despite this court's directions issued on October 20, 2023, deaths due to persons entering sewer/septic tanks is still occurring and that too in large numbers."

> SC NOTED THAT DESPITE ITS 2023 ORDER, MANUAL SCAVENGING DEATHS CONTINUE AND THAT TOO IN LARGE NUMBERS

Posting the matter after four weeks, the order said, "We call upon the chief secretaries of the 15 states to show cause as to why contempt proceedings not be initiated for wilful disobedience of this court's order."

Refusing to tolerate continuation of human scavenging, the bench categorically asserted, "Such deaths cannot go on when we have made it clear that no manual scavenging is to take place. We will now fix responsibility as somewhere the buck has to stop."

Senior advocate K Parameshwar, assisting the court as amicus curiae, pointed out that the 2023 verdict required all governments and civic bodies to take such steps by which humans are not required to enter sewer or septic tanks.

Citing the deaths recorded in the response to a Parliament question, he urged the court to ensure that the letter of the law laid down by the court is strictly enforced.

The bench said, "The directions issued by this court seem to have not percolated down and remedial steps have not taken place." The five states reporting maximum deaths in 2024-25 include Uttar Pradesh (17), Maharashtra (17), Rajasthan (13), Delhi (12) and Tamil Nadu (12).

Besides these states, the chief secretaries asked to respond by the court belong to Punjab, Haryana, West Bengal, Telangana, Madhya Pradesh, Karnataka, Gujarat, and Goa. Going by the 2023 deaths, even Bihar and Jharkhand were asked to respond as the figures did not specify whether the deaths occurred after the judgment.

1 KILLED AS TWO SPEEDBOATS COLLIDE IN U.P.

GORAKHPUR: A 20-year-old man was killed and eight others injured after two speedboats collided at Ramgarhtal Lake in Gorakhpur, prompting the district administration to ban boating after sunset and order a probe into the incident, officials confirmed on Monday.

The police have booked the two boat operators, Abhishek Sahni, 21, and Avinash Gaur, 20, and further legal action is underway, they said.The deceased, identified as Lakhmuddin, a Class 12 student from Kushinagar district, had come to the tourist spot with family and friends on Sunday. District magistrate Deepak Meena constituted a three-member inquiry panel to probe the incident. **PTI**

Kuki-Zos launch counter economic blockade

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IMPHAL: Kuki-Zo groups in Manipur have launched an indefinite counter economic blockade on the highway connecting the ethnic strife-torn state with neighbouring Nagaland, saying it will continue until the government ensures the free movement of essential commodities to their areas.

Naga and Meitei groups protesting the killings of six Naga hostages last month have intensified an economic blockade against Kuki-Zos.

Kuki Civil Society Organisation Working Committee said Kuki-Zo people of Ukhrul, Kamjong and Kangpokpi have endured "obstruction of essential commodities" while the government watched in silence. "All government and private institutions within the jurisdiction of 14 Kuki-Zo villages shall remain closed until further notice," said the committee in a statement on Sunday.

It added that the decision for the counter blockade was unanimously taken following consultations with the Kuki-Zo civil society organisations of Ukhrul and Kangpokpi.

Naga and Kuki-Zo tensions escalated in Manipur after May 13 twin ambushes left four people, including three church leaders, dead.

HT

SC to hear plea against release of Jagannath movie

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court agreed to hear on Tuesday an Odisha government plea challenging the release of animated film 'Mahaprabhu Jagannath' after it was granted screening clearance by the CBFC. The bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Vikram Nath and Justice B V Nagarathna agreed to hear the matter on Tuesday. Advocate General for Odisha, Pitambar Acharya, said the matter is a "little sensitive", asking for urgent listing.

Demolition of 38 buildings at Jauhar University stayed

MEERUT: In an interim relief to Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan's dream project, Moradabad divisional commissioner Anjaneya Kumar Singh on Monday stayed the Rampur Development Authority's order for the proposed demolition of 38 buildings at Mohammad Ali Jauhar University until the next hearing. This order means that no demolition or bulldozer operation can occur while the appeal is under consideration. The RDA issued the demolition order on July 15.

HC quashes TN govt order on jobs for Karur victims' families

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BANGALORE: The Madras high court on Monday struck down an order issued by the Tamil Nadu government granting compassionate appointments to the families of 41 people who died in the stampede in Karur during a TVK rally last September, holding that the decision violated Articles 14 and 16 of the Constitution and would open the "floodgates" for similar claims arising out of other tragedies.

A bench of justices CV Karthikeyan and R Sakthivel said public employment cannot become a form of compensation outside the constitutional framework governing appointments. If

In September 2025, 41 people died in a stampede during a TVK rally in TN's Karur.

the government extended jobs in one tragedy, it would become difficult to deny similar relief in other cases, the bench said.

"Public employment is not to be thrown away by the State. It has to be earned. Its value has to be realised. Its importance is to be cherished. There are many who wait seeking employment," the high court said.

The court noted that thousands of eligible applicants already waited for compassionate appointments under the existing scheme. The state cannot overlook their claims and create a separate class of beneficiaries through an executive order, it said.

The court added that the government should instead have funded "technical education, skill development, and entrepreneurship programmes" for eligible members of the affected families. "The government would be creating leaders, entrepreneurs, self-sufficient individuals in each family who can later provide employment to others," the high court said.

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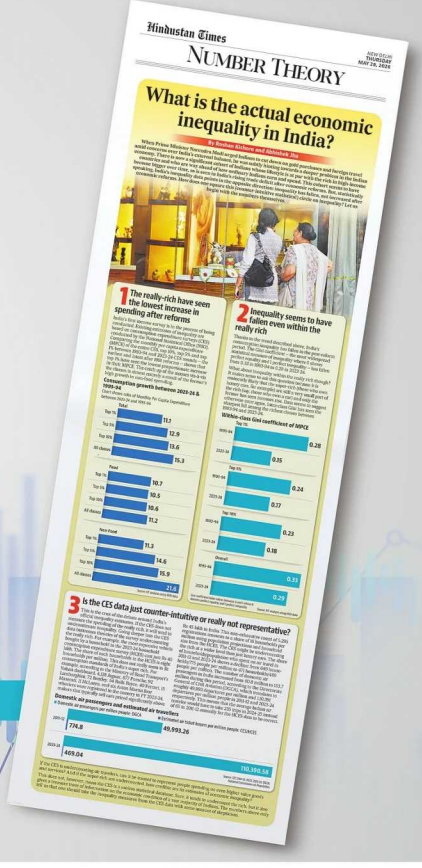

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SC likely to frame nationwide norms for handling of protests

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday indicated that it may frame nationwide guidelines governing the handling of protests, observing that while the constitutional right to peaceful protest must be protected, violence by demonstrators and excessive use of force by police were equally unacceptable.

A bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said that it was equally concerned about injuries suffered by protesters and police personnel during demonstrations, and stressed that "self-imposed discipline" by protesters and police personnel was integral to a functioning democracy. "There has to be a protocol in place. Everyone has a right to protest so long as it is with due permission and at designated places. But if some anti-social elements have done anything, that can also be looked into," CJI said.

Senior advocate Vikas Singh urged the court to evolve uniform norms. "There have to be pan-India guidelines and some kind of balancing," Singh submitted.

Agreeing that the issue transcended any one state, the CJI said all petitions would be heard together. "We will list all the matters tomorrow. Do not take it adversely. If there are excesses committed, that can be looked into dispassionately...who has done it etc...It is not a question of Delhi alone but it is an all-India issue. It cannot be that there is an agitation and hence a lathi charge. It can also not be that violence occurs in these protests," justice Kant added.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Delhi Police, said the police had no objection to all the petitions being heard together. "We are not taking it adversely. Let all matters be taken up together," Mehta submitted.

The observations came as multiple petitions concerning the nationwide protests over examination paper leaks, including allegations of police excesses during the July 20 "Sansad Chalo" march and subsequent incidents in Bihar, were mentioned before the bench, which also included justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

The hearing came against the backdrop of continuing litigation over the July 20 police crackdown. ANI

Mentioning one of the petitions, advocate Fauzia Shakil, appearing for Rajya Sabha MP Manoj Jha, told the court that a comprehensive writ petition was filed placing on record material relating to police action, including the firing on protesters in Bihar's Siwan district. "We have filed a writ petition with comprehensive information, including Bihar firing...There was use of AK-47 in Siwan...we have filed data," Shakil submitted.

Another counsel requested that multiple petitions and applications filed on behalf of students' families allegedly assaulted during the protests be heard together.

Responding, the CJI said the court was already seized of a petition seeking all-India guidelines on protests. "There is a petition seeking all-India guidelines for protests etc. The right to peaceful protest is guaranteed under the Constitution. So long as there is a peaceful protest, it is allowed," observed the CJI, as senior counsel Sankaranarayanan, appearing for petitioner-advocate Shailesh Mani Tripathi, said that his plea pressed for such guidelines.

The bench directed that all pending petitions be listed together on Tuesday.

Ahead of Tuesday's hearing, an application was filed by family members of four Delhi police personnel, including ACP Kailash Singh Bisht who sustained grievous injuries during the protests at Jantar Mantar. The family members demanded guidelines to be framed for protecting women and men in uniform from being assaulted while on duty and sought accountability to be fixed on all persons responsible for "instigating, abetting and inflicting" violence on law enforcement personnel.

Plea in SC to ban metallic pellets to disperse crowds

NEW DELHI: Retired Intelligence Bureau Special Director Yashovardhan Azad, along with two other victims of pellet gun injuries sustained during the July 20 protests, has moved the Supreme Court seeking a direction to decommission or prohibit the use of wholly or partly metallic kinetic projectiles or pellets fired from pump-action rifles or projectile-action guns by law enforcement agencies for dispersing civilian assemblies. The matter is likely to be mentioned before CJI Surya Kant on Tuesday. HTC

FIRs to be withdrawn, no legal action: Bihar

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PATNA/KOLKATA/PRAYAGRAJ: The Bihar government late on Monday said it will withdraw all cases registered against protesters and release those arrested in a statewide crackdown against demonstrators who took part in last week's strike supporting the protest called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) against the NEET question paper leak controversy.

"No adverse legal action - punitive/retaliatory - shall be taken by the Government against any individual participating in the protests before 6 PM on July 26, across the entire state," a notification issued by the state home department said. "Furthermore, all the persons arrested/detained in connections with the cases registered before the stipulated date, shall be released immediately."

The government's decision came amid widespread protests from civil activists, lawyers, political activists and CJP representatives who strongly condemned the Bihar police's continued crackdown against the protesters, sending hundreds of young protesters to judicial custody.

Police said 694 people were detained across the state in connection with the July 25 strike.

Of these, 355 youths had been remanded to judicial custody while 339 minors and others were released after age verification on Monday. Violence was reported from at least 13 districts, with Patna recording the highest number of detentions.

While the police had justified the actions as lawful, the victims' families alleged harassment. They claimed they were being subjected to deliberate confusion and brutality as their wards were being picked up while going on their daily routines.

In one case, Awadhesh Kumar Sharma, a mechanic from Aurangabad working in New Delhi, said his three sons — who were returning home after coaching classes in Patna — were arrested by Kankarbagh police. The eldest, Suresh Kumar, a polytechnic student, was sent to jail reportedly for making a statement against the Prime Minister. His younger brothers, identified as minors, were later released.

The government's decision came amid widespread protests in several districts over NEET issue. HT

Relatives alleged that detained students were brutally beaten and booked under serious, non-bailable sections of the Bharatiya Nyay Sanhita, including Section 109 (attempt to murder).

Crackdown in Bengal

Over a dozen people have been arrested in West Bengal for resorting to violence at rallies and demonstrations related to the protest, police said. Many of those arrested have been charged with damaging public property and vandalism.

At least 14 people were arrested earlier and remanded in police custody on Sunday when the police told the court that none of them were students.

"Two more men, identified as Waqr Azam and Md Javed Akhtar, were arrested from Bright Street and Nadial areas respectively on Monday. All 16 accused have been booked under the new West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-social Activities Act and the West Bengal Maintenance of Public Order (Amendment) Act," a police officer said, requesting anonymity.

Police action in UP

The Prayagraj police have arrested 10 suspects accused of vandalising vehicles during the student protests at Civil Lines on July 25 and registered three FIRs related to the incidents under sections 191 (2), 324 (4) and 109 (1) of the BNS. The latest complaint was lodged on Monday by a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader, who alleged that his vehicle was attacked and he received death threat by unidentified miscreants.

BIHAR CONSTABLE SUSPENDED FOR 'USING AK-47' ON NEET PROTESTERS

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PATNA: The Bihar government on Monday suspended a police constable after a video purportedly surfaced showing him using an AK-47 rifle during Bihar Bandh protest in Siwan district over the NEET issue, even as the police claimed that the jawan was not on duty to manage the agitation, officials aware of the matter said.

HT couldn't independently verify the veracity of the video.

The development comes after three protesters alleged that they have received gun shot injuries during July 25 protest in Siwan. The police, however denied the claims, saying those injured were not hit from the suspended jawan's assault rifle.

"The jawan identified as Abhishek Kumar has been suspended and a departmental proceedings initiated against him," Siwan superintendent of police Puran Jha said. "No one was injured in the firing."

District magistrate Vivek Ranjan Maitrey said the jawan did not act in accordance with law. "The jawan was neither supposed to fire nor carry an automatic weapon in front of the crowd. He was attached with district intelligence unit (DIU) passing through JP Chowk to investigate a separate murder case when he became trapped in a protest crowd. Caught in the commotion, he discharged four rounds into the air using an AK-47 assault rifle," Ranjan Maitrey said.

Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly Tejashwi Yadav also raised the issue. "During the protest in Siwan, police resorted to direct firing with an AK-47 on the students. When the accused criminal in seven murders becomes the chief minister, then in democracy, the police fire bullets like this at innocent students," Yadav said in a post on X.

Several RAF personnel issued pellet guns on Jul 20

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NEW DELHI: At least a dozen personnel of the Rapid Action Force(RAF) were issued pellet guns on the morning of July 20 to handle student protesters in Delhi but the controversial weapons were withdrawn starting July 23 after allegations that they were used against agitators, officials aware of RAF's internal inquiry said on Monday.

HT has reported that five people – Sheikh Irshad Mansuri, a 25-year-old employee with a private firm, Nootan Toppo, a 32-year-old woman from Gurugram, a 28-year-old reporter, Prashant Singh, a 25-year-old Bihar resident, and 19-year-old Sahil Lochab, a student aspiring to join the police force – have alleged (in Lochab's case the allegations were made by the family) that they were hit with pellets on July 20.

RAF is a specialised unit within the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) deployed to handle riots and other public disturbances across the country.

The internal inquiry also quoted a CRPF inspector – leading one RAF team in the Outer Circle of Connaught Place near Pallika Bazar on July 20 – as saying that he didn't issue any order to fire the pellet guns, the officials cited above added.

"It is possible more than one officer fired the pellet gun that afternoon. The personnel in the RAF inspector's team have been identified. The post assessment report submitted to headquarters will name the officer to whom the pump action guns were issued along with the specific number of cartridges containing pellets. There are also many deviations, including personnel not firing below the waist," an official aware of the matter said.

"But one thing is for sure that no pellet guns were issued on Thursday, Friday, or Saturday after the controversy. It won't be issued for any future protests by students unless the other group is armed," the official added.

HT has reported that five people have alleged that they were hit by pellets on July 20. PTI

Between 1pm and 5pm on July 20, the RAF team under probe was posted near the Grand Charkha installation above Pallika Bazar on the road leading to Jantar Mantar from the Connaught Place Circle.

"We have heard that in the RAF's internal inquiry, the personnel said that the pellet gun was fired when a Delhi Police team was hit by stones and people in the crowd pelted stones at the police and RAF personnel. The RAF team also told their seniors they had to escalate their response because Parliament was in session and protesters were set to march towards the Parliament Complex," a second officer added.

CRPF headquarters is yet to receive the report from the Inspector General (IG) of RAF, Seema Dhundia.

The officials cited above said that last Thursday and Friday, Dhundhia held two separate meetings – one with her officers within RAF and another with the CRPF top brass.

The IG's review meetings found many deviations by the CRPF personnel from standard operating protocol, prompting all CRPF and RAF personnel to attach their name tags to their uniforms from Friday. "During the review meeting, the team also found that many personnel were giving interviews on the ground or posting on their social media accounts. This is against service rules," the second official said.

Although the use of pellet guns – categorised as a non-lethal deterrent along with tear gas, rubber bullets and smoke grenades – is included in RAF's manual for crowd control, their use on student protesters has raked up a controversy, including in Parliament, and was termed inappropriate by the Opposition, students and police experts.

It was also the first time that pellets in pump action guns(PAGs) were used in Delhi. It has earlier been used in Jammu and Kashmir to handle violent agitations and stone pelting. During the 2021 farmers' agitation, police and CRPF used plastic bullets.

After the protests were called off on Saturday, CRPF chief GP Singh said, "Now, since agitation has been called off, and once assembled people disperse, we would make a professional post event assessment, like we do after every major assignment, and then let you know the view of the Force HQ."

Agreement being breached, CJP tells govt, threatens to resume stir

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Monday said students and protesters were being detained or arrested in various states, particularly Assam, Bihar and West Bengal, in violation of the agreement with the Centre last week, and threatened to return to street protests if it didn't stop.

The withdrawal of all cases and first information reports (FIRs) was part of the three conditions – the others being the resignation of former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan and ₹1 crore compensation to the families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide – involved in calling off the Jantar Mantar stir on Saturday.

To be sure, in the evening, Bihar announced that it will not take any legal action against people participating in protests before 6pm on July 26.

Ashutosh Ranka

"Dear @JPNadda, @DrJitendraSingh ji, we are observing a complete breach of the agreement regarding no police action against the protestors...we demand that all the FIRs against the protestors be immediately withdrawn, students be released and no future FIRs be filed...failing which we will be forced to sit on protest again," CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka said.

"We also demand that the written agreement around legal cases be shared with us by tomorrow, the aligned timelines with the Government of India," he added.

Later, Ranka and another spokesperson Saurav Das held a presser with senior advocate Kapil Sibal. Ranka said that the Centre had assured them that all FIRs will be withdrawn and no future FIRs will be filed against protesters. "We had shared the draft of this written agreement with JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh. It was agreed upon that by Tuesday, the government will share the written agreement and lawyers from both sides will finalise it. We are waiting for this written agreement...We hope that words of senior cabinet ministers will be honored. If this does not happen by tomorrow and people are not released, the CJP will be forced to protest again," he said.

During the meeting on Saturday, Union minister JP Nadda had said the CJP representatives came to the meeting with a written draft on cases filed during the July 20 agitation.

BJP seeks to regain control over narrative after student protests

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has set out to regain control of the political narrative after the Union government was pushed on the back foot over student protests that forced the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as education minister, said people aware of the details.

The party's attempts to quell anger among the younger demographic was precipitated by widespread protests that had erupted on the streets, the Opposition coalescing against the government in Parliament, and a few discordant notes within the party itself.

A senior party leader said the government has already announced a slew of measures to tackle irregularities in the conduct of examinations, such as setting up a high powered committee under Nandan Nilekani to suggest long-term reforms. "The opposition is trying to pit the BJP against the youth, whereas the steps that have been taken show that the government is sensitised about their concerns and took immediate steps to address those... the PM (Narendra Modi) himself communicated the measures being taken to ensure that students do not suffer," said a senior lawmaker.

The person said, unlike the government that remains responsive, the Opposition was yet to "admit or make amends" for paper leaks that happened on their watch.

"What has the AAP government done in Punjab, or the Congress government in Himachal Pradesh, where there were irregularities in the HP School examination board? In Jharkhand, papers of the JAC examination were leaked, while as in Telangana, the Intermediate language examination paper was leaked...the list is long," the lawmaker said.

Party leaders – who have borne the brunt of public anger -- are making efforts to woo the young. The party internally admits to course corrections, but is publicly blaming the "Opposition and vested interest" for stoking unrest among the youth.

On Monday, while campaigning for a bypoll in Bihar, party chief Nitin Nabin said the presence of "large crowds of younger people" at a rally he was addressing was an indication of the "youth being with the BJP."

Pradhan at Parliament

Former Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan was on Monday greeted by his party colleagues with slogans and a shawl, in a show of strength when he reached Parliament. Later, he referred to himself as a "street fighter and not an AC room activist" in a friendly exchange with an Opposition MP. PTI

{ OVER DEFAMATORY CONTENT }

HC allows Gadkari to sue Meta, Google

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MUMBAI: The Bombay high court on Monday allowed Union road transport minister Nitin Gadkari to file a civil suit against Meta, X Corp, Google LLC, and other such platforms over allegedly defamatory posts and artificial intelligence (AI)-generated deepfake content on social media targeting him and his family.

Justice Abhay Ahuja allowed the senior BJP leader to institute the suit against the social media platforms, enabling him to file for interim relief and a temporary injunction against allegedly defamatory and deepfake content falsely associating him with the Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP) programme and the E20 initiative.

Launched in 2014 to cut crude oil imports, the EBP programme has scaled rapidly since 2021 by incrementally blending ethanol produced from sugarcane, rice, and maize with petrol, reaching a milestone of 20% blending (E20) in 2025, five years ahead of the original target.

The plea filed through advocate Sandeep S Ladda said the defamatory content about Gadkari has been published, circulated and made available on the digital platforms owned, operated and/or administered by Meta, X Corp, and Google, and are freely accessible to the public.

Nitin Gadkari

"The defendants have intentionally made such content available to the public at large. These individuals are directly responsible for circulating, malicious, false, derogatory, and abusive content concerning the petitioner, including posts, tweets, reels, videos, photographs or any other digital or electronic material using AI-generated deepfake... without his knowledge, consent or authorisation," the plea said.

The court permitted the Union minister to file a civil suit against the online portals.

27 of 110 Radhakrishan panel suggestions unimplemented so far

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NEW DELHI: Nearly two years after the Union government accepted the recommendations of the K Radhakrishnan committee set up in the aftermath of the NEET-UG 2024 controversy, only 57 of its 101 recommendations (56.4%) have been fully implemented and another 10 (9.9%) have been partially implemented, an analysis by HT shows.

Among the promises implemented, the most prominent were restructuring the National Testing Agency (NTA), strengthening it with domain-specific leadership and manpower, and building psychometric expertise to modernise assessment methods. To be sure, these were set in motion only over the past week in the wake of sweeping student protests.

The earliest recommendations to be implemented were enhanced examination security measures introduced for JEE (Main) in January 2025, including Aadhaar-based authentication, strengthened frisking, repeat biometric verification after biobreaks and tighter candidate verification.

The government also announced plans to implement four more recommendations — introducing multi-session testing for large examinations, exploring a multi-stage format for NEET-UG, reducing the high-stakes nature of entrance exams through multiple opportunities, and eventually shifting NEET-UG to a computer-based, multi-session format — but is yet to roll them out.

A total of 27 recommendations (26.7%) remain unimplemented. This includes the proposed DIGI-EXAM identity verification system on the lines of 'Digi Yatra', hybrid and computer-assisted secure question paper transmission, mobile testing centres for remote areas, adaptive testing, oversight mechanism for coaching centres to reduce anxiety among students, international collaborations with global testing agencies, and the committee's recommendation that NTA should primarily conduct entrance examinations rather than recruitment tests.

This means 57 proposals were implemented, 10 partially implemented, and 27 not implemented; three recommendations are currently under implementation, and plans have been announced to implement another four.

Neither the education ministry nor NTA responded to HT's queries.

HT reached out to Radhakrishnan for a reaction, but couldn't get an immediate response.

Three recommendations are under implementation, and plans have been announced to implement another four. FILE

A key recommendation by the panel was to disengage NTA from conducting recruitment tests. But documents reviewed by HT show that despite then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's December 2024 announcement that NTA would stop conducting recruitment examinations from 2025, the agency continued to handle such tests.

In 2025, NTA conducted the Uttar Pradesh Civil Court Staff Centralised Recruitment examinations held on January 4–5 and the Stage-II examinations for the high court of Gujarat, district courts, industrial courts and labour courts recruitment drive-2024 in March and May. It was subsequently entrusted by the Allahabad high court with two fresh recruitment drives through advertisements issued on March 12 and June 1, 2026, for the posts of private secretary grade-I and review officer, assistant review officer and computer assistant.

In all, the NTA conducts 15 major national entrance and eligibility examinations with a permanent staff strength of just 24, supplemented by 73 contractual and 124 outsourced personnel.

A member of the Radhakrishnan committee said the recommendation to keep NTA out of recruitment examinations was intended to allow the agency to focus exclusively on entrance tests and strengthen its institutional capacity.

"The whole idea was that NTA should stay focused on entrance examinations rather than spreading itself too thin. If it continues taking up recruitment tests for various agencies, the purpose of that recommendation is defeated," the member said, requesting anonymity.

Another member said the panel "very clearly" recommended that NTA confine itself to entrance examinations. "Our responsibility was to examine the existing mechanism and submit recommendations. Their implementation is for the government to decide," the member said, declining to comment on why the recommendation was not followed.

The seven-member high-level committee, headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan, was constituted in June 2024 after allegations of irregularities in NEET-UG 2024. It submitted its report in October 2024 with 101 recommendations aimed at overhauling NTA through stronger governance, tighter oversight of outsourced vendors, enhanced coordination with states, and technology-driven safeguards for both pen-and-paper and computer-based examinations.

The committee divided its recommendations into two phases -- 60 short-term measures and 41 long-term structural reforms.

HT's analysis found that implementation was stronger in the first phase.

Of the 60 Phase-I recommendations, 46 were implemented, three partially implemented, two under implementation, three announced for rollout and six were pending. Prominent among them was rationalisation of CUET subjects from 63 to 37 from 2025 edition onwards.

By contrast, progress on long-term reforms was slower: of the 41 Phase-II recommendations, 11 were implemented, seven partially implemented, one under implementation, one was announced and 21 were pending.

Among the measures already implemented were strengthened governance mechanisms, closer coordination with state governments and test-indenting agencies, enhanced candidate verification and frisking, improved standard operating procedures, secure transportation and storage of question papers, AI-enabled surveillance, encryption protocols, better grievance redressal and tighter confidential examination processes.

Last week, after massive protests in Delhi over exam paper leaks,the government began to roll out structural reforms recommended in NTA. Sixteen new permanent posts were announced in NTA, which advertised specialist leadership positions in cybersecurity, digital forensics, assessment research and test-centre operations, besides recruiting young professionals through UPSC's PRATIBHA Setu portal. The agency said the hiring was aimed at reducing dependence on outsourced manpower and implementing the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations.

However, staffing remains a concern. Official data show that only 24 of NTA's 39 sanctioned permanent posts were currently filled, while the agency continues to rely on 73 contractual employees and 124 outsourced personnel.

Mahadev case proceeds may reach ₹43k-crore

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MUMBAI: Mahadev Online Book (MOB) and associated platforms like Skyexchange and Lotus 365 have generated proceeds of crime (POC) in the range of ₹36,000 to ₹43,400 crore through alleged illegal betting operations in the last seven years, said Enforcement Directorate (ED) officials.

This is the first consolidated provisional estimation of proceeds of crime of MOB and its allied betting platforms since ED began its investigation in October 2022. So far, the agency has filed five chargesheets against 74 persons and entities in the PMLA court at Raipur, Chhattisgarh.

ED officials told HT that they mentioned these figures in their June 5 provisional attachment order submitted by its Raipur unit to the PMLA adjudicating authority in New Delhi. The officials said that despite the crackdown by law enforcement agencies since 2022-23, illegal betting operations have continued through dummy and mirror sites resulting in mounting amount of POC.

Investigators said MOB—one of the largest illegal betting syndicates operating through franchise-based networks—generated over ₹450 crore every month which was then laundered through a layered network of shell entities, accommodation entries and financial transactions to disguise the funds as legitimate.

The ED's June 5 provisional attachment order pertained to

THE ED'S JUNE 5 PROVISIONAL ATTACHMENT ORDER PERTAINED TO ASSETS WORTH ₹940.77 CRORE LINKED TO DELHI-BASED BUSINESSMAN VIKAS GARG

assets worth ₹940.77 crore linked to Delhi-based businessman Vikas Garg. These assets, which include residential units, land parcels, equity shares and other securities, were allegedly purchased using laundered POC.

ED officials said the attached assets belong to Garg who has since been arrested, members of his family and entities either owned or controlled by him. He used the money allegedly routed from Skyexchange through various entities to acquire shares, securities and other assets, including the alleged acquisition of 97.58% shareholding of a US-based tech company Ebix Inc. through the United States Bankruptcy Court.

The Dubai-headquartered MOB concurrently operates more than 2,000 active platforms across India at any given time, with each platform generating average net profits of around ₹30-40 lakh per month (with 70-to-80 per cent flowing upward to the 'head office'). The aggregate POC generated by MOB and its other alleged allied platforms like Reddy Anna and FairPlay has been estimated at ₹4,000 to 5,000 crore per year "for the period from 2019 till date," ED officials stated in their June 5 provisional attachment order. This estimate is grounded in panel-level profit data allegedly extracted from seized electronic devices and reconciled with statements of panel operators recorded under the PMLA Act by the ED, the PAO said. An official clarified that the calculation and estimation is provisional in nature.

Skyechange and Lotus365 Platforms

The 'Skyexchange' online platform, in alleged partnership with MOB co-promoter Sourabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal, generated POC estimated at around ₹3,916 crore. This estimate is based on a detailed electronic spread-sheet document that the ED claimed to have recovered from the laptop of a certain individual identified only by the initials, "PB," during a search operation.

The document allegedly recorded the weekly earnings of Skyexchange for each of its 'Super Admin' accounts. The document reflects weekly earnings of around ₹22 crore across 178 weeks - from September 2020 to February 28, 2024. The alleged POC from 'Skyexchange was further corroborated by analyzing the bank account data of its operator's entities, statements from persons examined under the PMLA, and analyzing the investment portfolios of the Dubai-based Foreign Portfolio Investment (FPI) entities that the operator used as conduit vehicles for deploying the POC into Indian capital markets.

ED's investigation also revealed that analyses of seized digital data revealed that the MOB's promoters allegedly had "admin IDs" of the Skyexchange betting app. The MOB promoters were also allegedly authorised to further create "master" and "super IDs of Skyexchange betting app, which established that the promoters of MOB were partners in Skyexchange betting apps and were operating both the apps simultaneously, an ED official said.

The 'Lotus365' online platform is estimated to have allegedly generated POC of around ₹2,400 crore. The figure was arrived at based on estimated collection at the rate of ₹50 crore per month for around 48 months, from April 2020 onwards, said ED officials

The expansion of the MOB network is being viewed by investigators as a phenomenon given that its two alleged masterminds, Chandrakar and Uppal ran a juice shop and a small betting enterprise respectively in Bhilai. Within four years of the two men deciding to collaborate, the Mahadev Book was incorporated as "Mahadevbook Markets Limited" at Saint Vincent and the Grenadines in the Caribbean on June 21, 2021.

Chandrakar was detained in Oman last month and is awaiting his extradition to India. There are pending Interpol Red Corner Notices against both him and Uppal.

HC GIVES SONIA, RAHUL 3 WEEKS TO REPLY TO ED PLEA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi high court on Monday granted three weeks to senior Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and others to respond to the Enforcement Directorate's plea challenging a trial court order that refused to take cognisance of its charge sheet against them in the National Herald-linked money laundering case.

Justice Manoj Jain posted the matter for hearing on September 10. "We can't hear this today. There are two other time-fixed matters today.The board is heavy," Justice Jain said.

Senior counsel appearing for the respondents sought time to respond to the ED's plea.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing ED, said the trial court has "gone terribly wrong" in this case, and the respondents failed to file their replies, despite the HC giving them time to do so two months ago. "This is a pure question of law," he said.

The court granted the respondents three weeks to file the reply. SHRUTI KAKKAR

T'gana HC orders HYDRAA chief's 'immediate' removal

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana high court on Monday ordered the immediate removal of senior IPS officer A V Ranganath as commissioner of the Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (HYDRAA), holding him guilty of repeatedly committing contempt of court by ignoring its directions, people familiar with the matter said.

Hearing a contempt petition related to a 40-acre land dispute at Lothkunta in Secunderabad involving a private construction company, Justice Anil Kumar Jukanti directed chief secretary Sanjay Jaju to identify a suitable officer to replace Ranganath as HYDRAA commissioner.

HYDRAA is an agency constituted by the state government in July 2024 to protect lakes and land owned by the government from encroachments.

The petitioner alleged that HYDRAA officials entered the

THE BENCH ALSO NOTED THAT 63 CONTEMPT CASES WERE PENDING AGAINST THE CHIEF BEFORE THE HIGH COURT DURING HIS TENURE

disputed property despite subsisting judicial restraint orders, amounting to wilful disobedience of the court's directions.

Observing that the HYDRAA commissioner had repeatedly failed to comply with court orders, Justice Jukanti remarked that Ranganath had become "a law unto himself." The judge also noted that 63 contempt cases were reportedly pending against Ranganath before the high court during his tenure as HYDRAA commissioner.

The court had earlier directed Ranganath to appear in person and submit an unconditional written apology through an affidavit by Monday. However, he did not appear before the court, and his counsel informed the bench that they intended to file a petition instead. Taking serious exception to his absence, the judge viewed it as an act of wilful disobedience and directed the chief secretary to replace him with immediate effect.

Last week, the HC directed the Indian Army to take Ranganath into custody and lodge him in an army barracks for repeatedly violating court orders.

Reacting to the high court order, HYDRAA commissioner A V Ranganath said that he would contest all the contempt cases through legal means and expressed complete faith in the judiciary. He claimed that all the contempt cases against him were initiated by influential land grabbers. "My only mistake is standing in the way of such alleged encroachments," he added.

Smoke alert diverts IndiGo flight to Rajkot

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AHMEDABAD: An IndiGo flight from Dubai to Mumbai was diverted to Rajkot International Airport on Monday after the cockpit received a smoke indication from the aircraft's cargo hold, prompting the crew to declare an emergency, officials aware of the matter said.

Flight 6E-1452, an Airbus A321 carrying 185 passengers and crew, landed safely at Hirasar airport at 3.27 pm. All those on board were evacuated safely and no injuries were reported.

Airport authorities declared an emergency at 2.45 pm after receiving information from the flight crew about suspected smoke in

All those on board were evacuated safely at Hirasar airport. PTI

the cargo hold. Fire and rescue teams, along with other emergency services, were kept on standby before the aircraft landed.

"All 185 passengers, including two infants, and seven crew members are safe. The pilots detected smoke in the cargo area, following which the aircraft made an emergency landing at Rajkot. The aircraft has been taken for inspection," said Rajkot collector and district magistrate Om Prakash.

The aircraft was taken for inspection after passengers disembarked. The cause of the smoke indication is yet to be ascertained. The flight was operating from Dubai to Mumbai when the incident took place.

An IndiGo spokesperson said Flight 6E-1452 was "diverted to Rajkot International Airport today as a precautionary measure due to a technical issue".

"An inspection of the aircraft is currently underway before it is cleared to resume operations. An alternate aircraft is being arranged to complete the journey and in the meantime, we are assisting our customers..."

IIT-Guwahati student dies after fall; probe on

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SILCHAR: A Bachelor of Technology (BTech) student died on Sunday after allegedly falling from the fifth floor of a hostel building at the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Guwahati, police said on Monday. The student had secured an internship with the multinational financial services company Goldman Sachs and was known as a bright student with an excellent academic record.

An investigator said the student was rushed to a hospital, where he died during treatment. "His body has been sent for postmortem at Gauhati Medical College and Hospital (GMCH)."

The GMCH authorities refused to share the details regarding the cause of death while police awaited the postmortem report. "This is a sensitive matter. We are investigating thoroughly, so we cannot share the details. But yes, the student fell from the fifth floor and later died," the investigator said.

Police told news agency PTI that an investigation is underway and did not rule out the possibility of suicide.

In a statement on Monday, IIT Guwahati said that they are cooperating with the investigation and appealed against speculation. The institute said the student's parents from Odisha's Puri are on their way to the campus. "...the Institute is in close contact with the family, providing all necessary support during this difficult time. This is a profound loss to our IITG family," the statement said.

There have been a series of student deaths on the IIT Guwahati campus since 2022. In 2024, three students died within five months on the campus. The death of a third-year BTech Computer Science student from Uttar Pradesh's Ballia in his room in September that year triggered protests. The protesters questioned the mental health support system and demanded reforms at the institute, established in 1994 as the first IIT in the Northeast. IIT Guwahati has maintained it has strengthened its mental health support system.

"Through the SAATHI Counselling Club and the Centre for Holistic Wellbeing, IIT Guwahati provides students with access to licensed counsellors and psychiatrists," the statement said.

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{ IN HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS }

Ragging cases jumped over 100% in 4 yrs: Govt

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NEW DELHI: Ragging complaints from higher educational institutions across India increased to 1,369 cases in 2025, marking over a 100% jump from 655 in 2022, the Centre told the Lok Sabha on Monday, maintaining that its response to the problem remains "corrective and preventive."

Minister of state for education Sukanta Majumdar, in a written response to a set of questions from Trinamool Congress lawmaker Sayani Ghosh, said ragging complaints rose 46.9% in 2023 over the previous year, 12.7% in 2024, and 26.3% in 2025. Another 757 cases were reported this year till July 22, taking the cumulative count since 2022 to 4,827.

"The University Grants Commission (UGC) has issued Show Cause Notices to 107 HEIs including 18 Medical Colleges in 2025 for non-compliance with the mandatory provisions of the Anti-Ragging Regulations, 2009. These notices highlight lapses such as failure to secure anti-ragging undertakings from students and parents/guardians, and non-submission of institutional compliance reports despite repeated advisories and follow-ups," the minister said.

Ghosh had sought a year-wise, state-wise break-up of ragging complaints, details of action taken against errant institutions, and whether the Centre reviewed the effectiveness of the existing UGC anti-ragging framework.

"The regulatory approach has remained corrective and preventive, ensuring that institutions rectify lapses and adhere strictly to anti-ragging measures, thereby safeguarding student welfare and campus safety," the minister said.

The disclosure comes against the backdrop of a UGC-funded psychosocial study of ragging in colleges, which cites research showing victims report "significantly elevated rates" of depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation and attempts compared with students who were not ragged.

Among the states, Uttar Pradesh reported the highest 251 complaints in 2025, up from 97 in 2022. Bihar logged 122 cases in 2025, increasing from 54 in 2022. Madhya Pradesh saw the rise from 73 to 117 and Maharashtra from 41 to 89 in the period. West Bengal, meanwhile, reported a reverse trend, easing from a high of 121 cases in 2023 to 102 in 2025.

HT

NIA court acquits six Pak fishermen in Gujarat heroin case

AHMEDABAD: A special NIA court in Ahmedabad on Monday acquitted six Pakistani fishermen and an Indian fisherman in the 2019 Gujarat heroin smuggling case, citing gaps in the prosecution's account of the recovery of 217.856 kg of brown heroin. The six Pakistanis, however, were convicted under the Foreigners Act for illegally entering India. The court said the alleged recovery was "not found free from doubt".

Trainee IPS officer absconding after harassment case

HYDERABAD: Telangana police have launched a manhunt for trainee IPS officer Mulagani Uday Krishna Reddy after the high court refused him interim protection from arrest in a sexual harassment case involving a fellow trainee woman IPS officer. Police said Reddy was untraceable at both addresses mentioned in his petition. The probe is now being conducted by the Telangana Police Women Safety Wing's SHE Teams.

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Issues in anti-defection law are the making of MPs: SC

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NEW DELHI: Observing that "enormous issues" in the implementation of the anti-defection law are "the making of the members of Parliament", the Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a plea by senior advocate Kapil Sibal assailing interpretation of a provision that allows legislators to escape disqualification by way of a political party merger.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe issued notice on a petition filed by Sibal in his own name, questioning the interpretation of Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution that permits disqualification to be avoided where legislators claim protection under the merger provision, requiring a two-thirds threshold and allowing members to either join the new group or leave.

While agreeing to tag the matter with a similar pending case relating to the Goa political defections before a three-judge bench, Justice Narasimha remarked that although there were "enormous issues" with the working of the Tenth Schedule, the law was framed by Parliament itself.

THE TOP COURT AGREED TO TAG THE MATTER WITH A SIMILAR PENDING CASE RELATING TO GOA POLITICAL DEFECTIONS

"There are many issues. We will issue notice. These are issues that typically should be raised on the floor of the House. The Tenth Schedule is intended to regulate the mechanism between the legislators. We have upheld the Tenth Schedule. We have been seeing it. There are enormous issues with the Tenth Schedule. But who made it? It's the making of the MPs," observed the bench.

When Sibal, also a Rajya Sabha MP, argued that defects in the law had enabled governments to be toppled through engineered defections, the bench reiterated: "Who made it? It's the making of the members of Parliament. It is for the problems of the legislators to be decided."

Appearing in person, Sibal urged the court to entertain the petition under Article 32 of the Constitution, saying the issue had "huge repercussions" for Indian democracy and could fundamentally alter electoral mandates. "This matter is already pending...the Goa matter. But apart from that, this has huge repercussions to our polity. A political party has to take the decision. Please see the enormity of the problem. The electoral verdict can be changed. A minority can become a majority and a majority can become a minority," submitted Sibal.

He contended that the merger exception under the anti-defection law had become a tool to legitimise political defections that effectively overturned the mandate given by voters.

The bench indicated that such issues ordinarily belonged to the legislative and political domain. Sibal responded that constitutional courts could not remain passive merely because Parliament had enacted the law. He described the operation of the provision a "complete fraud".

The bench directed that the petition be tagged with the pending challenge concerning political defections in Goa, where the scope of the merger exception under the Tenth Schedule is already under consideration by a three-judge bench, headed by CJI Surya Kant.

Salman Khan

HC TO ORDER TAKE DOWN OF 'KALA HIRAN' TEASER

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Monday said it would pass an order directing take-down of links to the teaser of the proposed film 'Kala Hiran: The Battle for Legacy', touted to be inspired by actor Salman Khan's 1998 blackbuck poaching case, as well as interviews given by the film's producer, Amit Jani, within 24 hours.

Viewing the teaser in open court, a bench of justice Jyoti Singh opined that the producer was committing contempt of court by depicting events that were still sub judice and that even 24 hours of public circulation could inflict damage on a person's reputation.

"Every minute it is on public domain it is harming the reputation of the plaintiff (Khan) here...You can't do this even to a common man...Reputation is built with great effort; once it's lost, it's lost," the court said to Jani's lawyer. **SHRUTI KAKKAR**

Centre may pause pulse stock sales as El Nino risk grows

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NEW DELHI: The Centre has asked the agriculture ministry to relax the Price Support Scheme (PSS) norm requiring government-procured pulse stocks to be disposed of within nine months, as it seeks to preserve inventories amid emerging El Nino-related weather risks that could hit kharif production and fuel food inflation.

Under PSS, the government buys pulses, oilseeds and copra from farmers at MSP when market prices fall below MSP, primarily to protect farmers' incomes.

An internal communication in this regard, seen by HT, shows that the Department of Consumer Affairs (DoCA) requested the Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare to exempt the 2025-26 tur and chana stocks from the existing disposal timeline so that they can be retained to meet any supply shortfall in the coming months. The move, as per the letter, would strengthen preparedness against production losses arising from adverse weather while ensuring adequate availability of pulses at affordable prices.

According to the letter sent to agriculture secretary Atish Chandra last week, consumer affairs secretary Nidhi Khare said the department has been closely monitoring the availability and price situation of pulses during the ongoing kharif season.

Preliminary assessments indicate "emerging El Nino-induced weather-related uncertainties" that could influence acreage and crop performance in some regions, although the overall implications for production are still unclear. PSF is a buffer stock mechanism under which procured stocks are held and released into the market when needed to augment supplies and curb price spikes, thereby protecting consumers. DoCA said decisions on the open market sale of pulses and future procurement under the PSS may need to be reviewed in light of the evolving climatic situation.

Kharif sowing sees recovery after improved rainfall

NEW DELHI: Kharif sowing has staged a sharp recovery after improved rainfall in July, but total acreage remains below last year's level, with the shortfall concentrated in coarse cereals, rice and pulses even as experts and economists warn that crop yields, not acreage, will determine the eventual harvest amid strengthening El Nino conditions.

As of July 24, farmers had sown 82.62 million hectares under kharif crops, down 4.9% from the corresponding period last year, according to the agriculture ministry's latest sowing data. Latest figures indicate that kharif sowing has recovered significantly after lagging by about 23% at the beginning of July, when an almost 40% rainfall deficit in June had delayed planting. India's cumulative monsoon rainfall deficit stood at 15% as of Sunday. **HTC**

Victim of 'digital arrest' mistook cops to be fake

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MUMBAI: Acting on a tip-off, when Mumbai police arrived at the Grant Road home of a 75-year-old to protect him from a fake cop scam on July 25, the victim refused them entry, choosing to call the fraudsters instead for advice, officers said, adding that it took much persuasion and coordination between the police and housing society members to turn the tide.

The cyber cops were acting on information that the man had transferred ₹1.64 crore in tranches to various bank accounts between June 8 and July 25. But when they arrived at his door to restrain him from making further payments, he thought they were fake cops. He shut them out and made a WhatsApp video call to the people he had been interacting with and to whom he was remitting money.

The impersonators emphasised that they were the real cops and those at his door were imposters. "Despite the team's repeated urging, he refused to open the door," said a police officer attached to South Cyber police station.

Failing a breakthrough, the cyber police team in plain clothes then summoned uniformed policemen from the local police station and members of the housing society to gain access to the senior citizen's residence. The victim finally relented when three members of the society and a team of cops, who brought along another victim of cyber fraud, spelled out the reality for him.

The South Cyber police have booked the unknown accused under relevant sections of BNS, and are trying to identify them through the banking trail.

Leave 'denied over bribe', teacher delivers stillborn

RANCHI: A government school teacher delivered a stillborn child allegedly after district education officials withheld her application for child care leave while demanding a ₹50,000 bribe in Jharkhand's Palamu district, her husband has alleged. District authorities have, however, denied the charges, but suspended one official and transferred another.

Complainant Mukesh Kumar Tiwari, a police officer posted in Hazaribagh, has requested a murder probe against Palamu district education officer Sandeep Kumar and two clerks, Ishwari Dayal Ram and Arun Kumar Giri. "DEO, his staff and institutional negligence led to the death of my child and left my wife fighting for her life..."

Bharti Pandey, who works as a teacher at the Kasturba Gandhi Residential School in Chainpur, applied for Child Care Leave on July 3, said Tiwari, adding that when she followed up, the clerks and DEO demanded ₹50,000, forcing her to continue travelling long distances, leading to her hospitalisation and death of the foetus.

DEO said: "Allegation of bribe demand is wrong. Delay behind the sanctioning of leave was due to late presentation of the file..."

A statement from the office of deputy commissioner Dilip Pratap Singh Sekhawat said: "Bharti Pandey had not applied for maternity leave... she had submitted an application to the District Education Officer's office for 'Child Care Leave,' citing the need to care for her 7-year-old daughter... the DEO, Palamu, sanctioned 185 days of Child Care Leave via Letter No. 1069 dated July 25, 2026..." "The patient was found to have a complaint of 'Leaking P/V' (vaginal fluid leakage)..." **RAJ KUMAR**

PARL-EXAM BILL

ther strengthened the spirit of consensus and dialogue within the House," the official added.

Birla allotted six hours for the debate and the Opposition already submitted 93 amendments to the bill, setting the stage for a fiery debate against the backdrop of the student protests that forced Pradhan's ouster. The former minister walked into Parliament on Monday with a smile to a rousing welcome by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leaders and sloganeering in his favour, drawing criticism from the Congress.

The bill was introduced amid protests and slogans. The Lok Sabha was repeatedly adjourned through the day as the Opposition refused to relent.

When the Lok Sabha met at 5pm, parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju said, "All the members have come prepared. The Opposition has also given amendments. They, too, have prepared. This is an important bill for the youth and the students. From day one, they were asking for debates. But now they are behaving this way."

Telugu Desam Party's Krishna Prasad Tenneti nudged the Opposition, which had rushed to the Well of the House, "We have been waiting for a long time for this bill. You too, want to debate. I know many members have come prepared. Don't you want to discuss the future of the country's youth?"

The new bill substantially amends the 2024 Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, in line with promises made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the wake of surging protests by students. The new bill proposes to finish trials within three months from the filing of the charge sheet, a special task force, time-bound probe, and daily proceedings during trial.

According to the proposed law, anyone resorting to "unfair means and offences", shall be punished with imprisonment for a term not less than "five years but which may extend up to ten years and with fine up to ₹50 lakh". Similarly, the service provider can be punished with a fine of ₹5 crore and the proportionate cost of exam shall also be recovered from the service provider, who will be barred from any responsibility for a public examination for eight years.

In the current law, the jail term for unfair means and offences was three to five years with ₹10 lakh fine. Service providers' fine was ₹1 crore with a ban for four years.

In the morning, Congress chief and Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge led the charge in the Upper House. "It has never happened in the history of India that boys were beaten and dragged. Amit Shah ji is responsible!"

He later posted on X, "It is one of the gravest assaults on democracy in our history. Never before have students been beaten, dragged, and treated like criminals for raising their voices. Home minister Amit Shah must be held accountable! In Bihar, reports indicate use of AK-47 against students. True? Why are students being picked up in BJP ruled states?... Those responsible cannot escape accountability."

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said the system was "murderous" and slammed the government.

"The entire system is downright murderous against students. News is coming in that AK-47 bullets have been fired at protesting students in Bihar, and hundreds of students have been arrested with FIRs being filed against them. Mr. Modi, where did your promise go that no FIRs would be filed against students and they would be released? Instead, deadly attacks and brutality are being unleashed on them," Gandhi said.

"In Delhi, pellet guns were fired at students, and in Bihar, AK-47s. Whether it's Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Bihar, or Delhi — the pattern is the same everywhere. Mr. Modi, apologise to the country's students. And take action against those who attacked and crushed the students — not against the students themselves," he added.

Trinamool Congress's Rajya Sabha leader Derek O'Brien called for further steps.

"We must not fail our students and youth. We must not let them down. All credit to the champions. They have done the heavy lifting. From here onward, whatever we MPs from the Opposition do inside Parliament and outside Parliament and on the streets must reflect that," he tweeted.

As the Lok Sabha saw repeated protests, the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha sought Shah's statement on the use of pellet guns.

"What is the purpose of bringing the bill when the existing law on checking unfair means has not been used. So many cases of paper leaks happened, what did the government do...We are of the firm view that NEET should be abolished," Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam's Tiruchi Siva said.

The ruling coalition attacked the Opposition for not allowing Parliament to work. "Dharmendra Pradhan resigned from his position, taking responsibility. The PM himself announced the setting up of fast-track courts for swift justice and a high-powered group to suggest education reforms...yet, the Opposition is stalling both Houses," said a senior BJP leader.

SAIDULAJAB REPORT

report, submitted by the district magistrate (south) to the chief secretary earlier this month and seen by HT.

The report also questioned what it described as attempts by the MCD to shift responsibility for the collapse by attributing it to the excavation of an underground water tank without technical evidence, saying such conclusions appeared to be based on assumptions rather than verified findings.

MCD officials did not respond to HT's queries for a comment on the report.

Those killed in the tragedy comprised Ravi Prakash (26), a doctor; Ekta (23); BTech graduates Kapil (26), Alok Verma (23) and Nalin Rai (23); and Parvati Ojha (39), who ran the small eatery where several people were present when the collapse occurred. The incident exposed multiple violations, with the most blatant one being the illegal expansion of the building,

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

police found. Constructed 13 years ago, its third- and fourth-floors were newly constructed, according to a June MCD report. The building owner, Karamveer, and two contractors, Manish Khatri and Avinesh Gupta, were later arrested.

The collapse was part of a larger string of accidents, building collapses and blazes — including the June 3 Hauz Rani fire in which 23 people died, the July 8 Rohini Sector 16 twin building collapse (3 dead), the May 3 Vivek Vihar fire (9 dead) and the March 18 fire at a residential-cum-commercial building in Palam (9 dead) — that underscored poor monitoring, lax regulations and flagrant flouting of rules by multiple agencies and the police.

On July 25, HT reported that the magisterial inquiry into the deadly Hauz Rani fire indicted multiple government agencies for failures that allowed an illegally expanded building to continue operating as a bed-and-breakfast despite repeated warnings.

The Saidulajab report said "certain officials" appeared to have "created false and fabricated official documents" — show-cause notices dated May 27 and a work-stop notice dated May 29 — after the building had already collapsed.

"The apparent purpose of preparing these documents retrospectively was to mislead the inquiry, create a false record of official action and conceal their lapses, negligence and failure to discharge their statutory duties," the report said.

The report noted that the unauthorised third and fourth floors were acted against by MCD only on May 27, three days before the collapse though the illegal floors were flagged earlier in March.

According to the report, the MCD received a complaint regarding unauthorised construction on March 9, which was forwarded to the concerned officials on March 12. However, the civic body failed to produce any records before the inquiry committee "showing any inspection, verification, booking, demolition action or preventive measures taken pursuant to the complaint for more than two months".

Describing this as evidence of possible administrative failure, the report said, "this indicates possible inaction on the complaint received", while also pointing to "inadequate field monitoring".

During his deposition before the inquiry committee, the junior engineer said he could not inspect the site because of a lack of time and other official responsibilities.

The report also highlighted that the building's actual height and structural condition were never properly verified. It said the MCD's responses did not indicate any "proactive mechanism" adopted "to identify structurally unsafe buildings or dangerous construction activities, especially in densely populated areas".

The inquiry also examined the medical treatment provided to Kapil, one of the deceased, noting that he underwent multiple referrals before receiving definitive care.

An autorickshaw driver, who appeared as a witness, told the inquiry that he first took Kapil to a nearby hospital, which allegedly refused treatment. The hospital, however, denied that the patient was ever brought there. Kapil was subsequently taken to Pt Madan Mohan Malviya Hospital, which referred him to Safdarjung Hospital, where he was declared dead.

"While it cannot be conclusively stated, in the absence of expert medical opinion, that the patient would certainly have survived, it cannot be ruled out that timely admission, prompt stabilisation and appropriate emergency management at the earliest stage could have materially improved the patient's chances of survival," the report said.

The inquiry concluded that effective enforcement of structural safety norms could have prevented the tragedy and recommended fixing accountability not only on field-level officials but also on supervisory officers who failed to exercise effective oversight.

Among its recommendations were mandatory structural safety audits of old, high-risk and unauthorised buildings, stricter inspections, and joint inspection teams comprising the MCD, Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Police, the Disaster Management Authority and power utilities.

It also recommended GIS-based mapping, digital monitoring of vulnerable structures, periodic field inspections, risk categorisation of unsafe buildings, and immediate demolition or evacuation wherever necessary.

The report further called for a public grievance portal and a dedicated helpline to report unsafe constructions.

On emergency medical response, the inquiry said both government and private hospitals should be equipped to handle critically injured patients, noting that delays in diagnosis and treatment can significantly reduce survival chances. It also recommended stronger coordination among hospitals, police and emergency services, along with preservation of CCTV footage and medical records.

Invoking the Disaster Management Act, 2005, the report recommended disciplinary action against officials responsible for negligence and called for regular training, public awareness campaigns and strict implementation of disaster management guidelines.

It said stronger institutional accountability and preventive enforcement are essential to prevent similar tragedies.

IRAN-US WAR

tively collapsed over the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesman, Esmail Baghaei, said earlier Monday that while "it's possible that mediators share messages from the US side about current developments," no formal negotiations are currently taking place.

Tensions in the region remain high, and the Iran-backed Houthis claimed on Monday they targeted Saudi Arabian oil facilities with drones, although they didn't say when. Saudi Arabia hasn't announced an attack from Yemen since Saturday morning, though did say Monday it intercepted several drones launched from Iraq at petroleum facilities.

Axios reported Sunday that Admiral Brad Cooper, the top US commander overseeing the Middle East, recommended stopping strikes because they had reached the limit of their effectiveness, citing sources in the region.

Iran's army said it halted its retaliation against US bases and troops in the region as a result of Trump's decision to hold off on strikes. The Islamic Republic had been attacking the likes of Kuwait, Bahrain and Jordan on a near-daily basis in the two weeks before the US's pause on Friday.

Brent crude fell almost 6% in early trading on Monday to under $91 a barrel, after climbing 10% last week on the worsening fighting.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is scheduled to meet Trump in Washington on Tuesday. He said he plans to press the US leader on keeping a "constant watch" on Iran's nuclear program".

Iran has said there's no change to the status of the Strait of Hormuz, meaning it's likely to continue targeting commercial ships that don't receive its permission before transiting. Traffic through the vital waterway remains negligible.

On Monday, Iranian state TV said Tehran forced six ships going through the southern corridor near the Omani coast to turn around. One of the ships suffered an "incident," according to the reporting, which cited an Iranian official.

"We have never allowed, and will never allow, the United States to determine the timing of the war," an Iranian foreign ministry spokesman said separately on Monday. "We will defend ourselves whenever our interests require it, and we will certainly use diplomatic tools whenever we feel it is appropriate."

The US, meanwhile, is maintaining its blockade on Iran's ports.

The lull in fighting came as Iranian and Omani officials met over the weekend in a fresh attempt to resolve shipping through Hormuz. Iran said the talks were constructive and some progress was made, though gave no details, adding consultations were continuing. The clashes between the Houthis and Saudi Arabia over the past week have also ratcheted up risks for shippers. The Houthis, a militant group based in Yemen, fired on vessels in the southern Red Sea after threatening any calling at Saudi ports.

REBEL TMC MPs SET TO JOIN NDA PARL PANEL MEET

NEW DELHI: The 20 rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs will join a meeting of the NDA Parliamentary Party on Tuesday, signalling the final step towards alignment with the ruling dispensation, even as their appeal for the formal recognition as NCPI lawmakers are pending before Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla's office.

"...All Hon'ble NDA Members of the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha are requested to kindly make it convenient to attend the programme and be present at the venue well in time," read the invitation to the TMC rebels.

Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, a key face of the NCPI, said, "NCPI members will be present."

On Monday, TMC's Abhishek Banerjee submitted two letters to Birla, urging him to expedite a decision on the party's petitions for disqualification of its 20 rebel MPs and revoke changes made to the seating arrangements of its parliamentarians. HTC

GUJARAT AYURVED VARSITY ORDERS PROBE INTO PAPER LEAK ALLEGATIONS

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AHMEDABAD: Gujarat Ayurved University in Jamnagar has ordered an inquiry into allegations that the third-year BAMS Shalya Tantra-I examination paper was leaked, with questions allegedly circulated on WhatsApp groups before the July 20 test. Students claimed that 11 of the 12 questions matched those shared earlier and marked as important.

"We have received a complaint about an alleged paper leak... We will investigate whether there was any irregularity and whether the allegations are true," said H P Jhala, the university's in-charge director of examinations. The university said that the inquiry would determine if there was any breach in the exam process .

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{ OUR TAKE }

System needs to clean the system

Cabinet secretary has made an attempt to encourage the bureaucracy to break the mould of fossilized attitudes

Gen Z concerns are sneaking into spaces they have no business being in. Like, in India's cabinet secretary's letter on work culture and allied matters to his younger colleagues posted across the country. By talking about mundane routine work, behavioural shifts, and the need for introspection, Dr TV Somanathan has made an attempt to encourage Indian bureaucracy to break the mould of fossilized attitudes, many inherited from the colonial system. And he has begun this process by taking on the dreaded M word. Meetings. Even the seniormost bureaucrat of this country clearly shares the Gen Z disdain for "overstretched" and "directionless" meetings.

According to a recent survey, Indian employees spend nearly nine hours per week in meetings. While civil servants, who are supposed to be informed and intelligent generalists, ought to spend time in coordination and feedback activities — meetings being one of them — there's a risk of many meetings being rendered meaningless by indecision and the status-quoist approach. Somanathan, as a scholar of bureaucratic affairs, has been underscoring these issues for at least two decades. It is widely acknowledged that bureaucrats' suboptimal performance often stems from their tendency to safeguard their personal and professional interests through inaction. The arbitrariness of postings, empanelment, and transfers feeds into the insecurity of civil servants, despite the promise of a stable government job — Holy Grail for an average Indian.

According to global surveys, India's bureaucratic red tape has been historically rated as one of the most suffocating in Asia. While corruption may empirically appear to be the biggest issue plaguing Indian bureaucracy, the lack of defined Key Performance Indicators for civil servants is a much bigger problem. Less than 5% bureaucrats in India face KPI-based appraisals. This is both a reward and punishment. It is the latter for hardworking and innovation-oriented officers who find it difficult to stay motivated. For the truant ones, it is a security blanket. With his letter, Somanathan, once again, has worn his scholarly hat to highlight and address the issue of the bureaucracy's collective performance. With a nudge towards accountability and efficiency, along with the release of a handbook on conducting meetings, he has made it clear that it is the system that needs to clean up the system.

In Karnataka, a Cong heavyweight exits

The announcement by former Karnataka chief minister (CM) Siddaramaiah that he will not contest any future elections because he is old and politics is corrupt has the potential to transform the southern state's politics — if he sticks to his words. The 79-year-old leader — the longest-serving CM in a state where governance has historically been fractured and chaotic — not only built his brand around his humble beginnings but also stitched together a coalition of backward castes, Dalits and Muslims that propelled the Congress to its biggest victory in a generation in 2023. Now that the party has pivoted to DK Shivakumar, a strongman with ample resources who has been the party's chief troubleshooter for years, the possible retirement of Siddaramaiah holds possibilities. It can consolidate Shivakumar's hold over the government and make him the undisputed leader of the party that enjoys broad but thin support throughout the state. But he will have to hold on to Siddaramaiah's grassroots support, especially that of backwards and Dalits. Can he emerge as the undisputed leader of the Vokkaligas, one of the two most dominant castes in the state which has traditionally backed the now-atrophying JD(S)? And will Siddaramaiah's supporters continue to back the Congress or splinter? For a party that has essentially been reduced to a South Indian outfit, winning the 2028 assembly elections is an existential issue for the Congress. To do so, it has to resolve the contradictions left behind by Siddaramaiah's exit.

The BJP must be smiling. Since the ouster of Lingayat strongman BS Yeddiyurappa, the party has struggled to find a popular face to lead it in the only southern state it has formed a government. The exit of Siddaramaiah can create a churn that may help the BJP find its bearings before 2028. But all will depend on whether the wily veteran really means to retire, or if this is yet another tantrum to disrupt the plans of his successor.

South Asian youth rallies: 'Same same, but different'

While the subcontinent has seen serious student-led resistance movements, India's path ahead differs significantly from what happened in the neighbourhood following these protests

Street-protests create their own political rhetoric which must catch up with the institutional realities of the country. ANI

Lived reality always finds a way to catch up with political rhetoric. In February 2021, Myanmar's youth protested a military coup that eventually became a grinding civil war. In March 2022, former Sri Lankan president Gotabaya Rajapaksa felt the force of gravity when power cuts and fuel shortages triggered mass protests. In May 2023, the Pakistani army faced its most severe test when mounting economic discontent and the jailing of former prime minister (PM) Imran Khan led to anti-establishment protests. In July 2024, former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina faced reality in the form of a student-led uprising. In September 2025, Nepal's Gen-Z decided to put an end to the excruciating decade-long saga of prime ministerial musical chairs in Kathmandu. In July 2026, India's Gen-Z showed its government the limits of a rising power's jobless growth and eroding structures of public accountability.

In essence, aspirational but disillusioned youth is reshaping the historical arch of a subcontinent that accounts for one-quarter of humanity.

The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP)'s protest, with support from education activist Sonam Wangchuk's 26-day hunger strike, that led to the resignation of the education minister Dharmendra Pradhan to account for the leak of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) question paper, drew comparisons with the youth-led protests in the neighbourhood. The visuals of young people standing up to the might of the State to express the frustration that comes from the gulf between the haves and the have-nots were indeed strikingly similar. That these protests received large societal support, be it in Myanmar or Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, or Pakistan, is also a point of convergence. But that is also where the similarities end. India is not a military dictatorship like Pakistan and Myanmar, nor is it the kind of civil autocracy Hasina built in Bangladesh. Equally, India's political system, despite its flaws, is neither as unstable as pre-2025 Nepal, nor is PM Narendra Modi as embattled as Rajapaksa was in Colombo.

Avinash Paliwal

So, what now, on the proverbial morning after? India's students and the government are, oddly, lucky to have five different pathways to learn from. Myanmar and Pakistan's militaries responded in the only language they knew. Unencumbered by electoral politics or accountability, these regimes opened fire on their citizens. The results are there for all to see. Myanmar is a civil war-ridden, economically broken country with State authority reduced to a rump. Ethnic armed organisations — no paragons of democracy themselves — are running parallel systems in territories they control. Pakistan continues to face ethnic and Islamist violence, but has temporarily stabilised its economy. Submission to the coercive powers of the army by traditional political parties has imparted a false sense of calm. There is enough simmering disquiet in Pakistani society and within the military institution itself; Munir's political shine could come undone just as fast, and unexpectedly, as it got built.

The cases of Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, and Nepal, all three of which conducted free and fair (if not inclusive, in Dhaka's case) elections after the uprisings, are more instructive. In Bangladesh, the interim government (IG) led by Muhammad Yunus was hugely invested in accountability. If it were not for the Bangladeshi army's decision to not fire at its citizens, Hasina would have pressed ahead along Pakistan's and Myanmar's path and killed a lot more than the 1,400 deaths estimated by the United Nations. The IG still managed to bungle Hasina's trial-in-absentia, and her prospective return to Dhaka risks destabilising the country all over again. Dhaka is in an awkward position where it seeks Hasina's extradition from India, but its main political parties have also concluded that, for now, they don't want the Awami League to return to active politics.

In Nepal, PM Balendra Shah remains politically stable and enjoys public support. But he continues to struggle on key questions around the economy and international diplomacy. His strength as an independently elected mayor of Kathmandu who talked less and delivered more struck a chord with Nepal's Gen-Z. Today, his conservative — and abrasive, according to critics — communicative style is becoming a liability as people demand more explanation for policy decisions. In Colombo, PM Anura Kumara Dissanayake remains popular. But he too is struggling to deliver promised constitutional, public sector, governance, anti-corruption, and economic reforms. Unlike Bangladesh, both Nepal and Sri Lanka opted for a more conciliatory approach towards ousted political parties and leaders after the initial uprisings and, for this reason, are less susceptible to recurring political crises than Bangladesh, Pakistan, and Myanmar.

If there is one thing for the Indian government to learn from these cases, it is this: Evasion of accountability may emerge from, or exude, short-term confidence. But it is almost certain to lead to worse second-order effects later. The haemorrhaging of public institutions to serve the executive pushes democratic dissent to the streets. Pradhan's resignation has prevented the protests from snowballing into an entrenched crisis. But the problem of education sector reform remains. The students deserve good education and employment opportunities. The government has three more years to usher in meaningful reform to deliver on these promises before it meets the electorate at the poll booth in 2029.

If there is one thing India's protesting students can learn from their regional peers, it is this: Their collective strength has produced a watershed moment in Indian politics. It also marks the end of political innocence and the coming of age of an entire generation. This energy will dissipate if not channelised using existing parliamentary structures. Sooner rather than later, and fairly or not, they too will begin to be judged along political lines. Such has been the fate of all Gen-Z movements in the subcontinent. After all, street-protests create their own political rhetoric which, too, must catch up with the institutional realities of the country.

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Processes, not outcomes, as base for education reforms

Students vociferously demanded accountability for repeated examination paper leaks, and rightly so. However, entrance examinations are merely the gateway to higher education institutions that are themselves facing deep structural challenges. According to recent data, nearly 38% of faculty positions at the IITs remain vacant. *Ad hoc* and contractual lecturers are often paid meagre salaries, forcing some to take up additional work simply to support their families. All of this is happening even as institutional fees have risen manifold over the past decade. Despite this, a significant proportion of our graduates remain unemployed. Curricula in many institutions remain outdated, with students often being taught content that has changed little in the last two decades. Meanwhile, research misconduct has reached unprecedented levels. Numerous colleges and universities lack the infrastructure required for state-of-the-art laboratories or even adequate facilities to support quality education.

Achal Agarwal

In such a situation, we must resist the temptation to focus solely on the outcomes — exam scores, rankings, placements, and admissions — and instead scrutinise the processes that produce them. Paper leaks are perhaps the easiest problem to solve. They have already been solved elsewhere. International examinations such as the SAT, TOEFL, and GMAT are conducted routinely and securely at scale. Their models can be studied and adapted. However, our admission process must move away from these unidimensional measures that put undue stress on our students while discouraging creativity, critical thinking, and holistic development.

In a country where a number of students want to become computer engineers, they spend most of their school time staying away from computers as it "distracts" them from the subjects that are tested in entrance exams. A more holistic approach would not only reduce unhealthy pressure but also reward exceptional students who may not fit the conventional mould. To be fair, some progress has been made through alternative admission pathways introduced by the IITs. Such efforts should be expanded across institutions and disciplines.

The more difficult challenge lies in reforming research. For years, we have been preoccupied with climbing international university rankings. Yet these rankings are not beyond scrutiny. Many are produced by for-profit organisations that derive revenue from the very institutions they rank. Several also maintain partnerships with academic publishers whose business interests are aligned with increasing publication output. When metrics become targets, integrity often becomes collateral damage. The consequences are already visible. Research misconduct in India has risen sharply since 2022. India produced roughly 5% of the world's research output in 2025, yet accounted for nearly 20% of reported research misconduct cases. This is damaging India's scientific reputation. Increasingly, even legitimate research from Indian institutions is viewed with scepticism. Trust, once lost, is painfully slow to rebuild.

Research excellence cannot be manufactured overnight. World-class laboratories are built through sustained investment over years, often decades. They require money, infrastructure, mentorship, and human capital. Yet India currently spends only about 0.64% of its GDP on research and development, roughly one-fourth of the global average. The recently announced RDI Fund of ₹1 lakh crore may help address some of the funding gap. However, unless research integrity is embedded into evaluation systems, there is a real risk that additional funding will simply be captured by those who have become adept at gaming flawed metrics.

Perhaps the biggest casualty of this obsession with rankings has been education itself. Teaching quality rarely features prominently in ranking systems because it is difficult to quantify. As a result, it is often sidelined during recruitment, promotion, and evaluation processes. Professors have little incentive to invest time in pedagogy, curriculum reform, or mentoring when publishing another paper offers greater rewards in terms of career advancement. There is little room for someone who may be an outstanding teacher but an average researcher.

The problem is compounded by the widespread reliance on *ad hoc* and contractual faculty. Many are paid salaries so low that they sometimes earn less than gig-economy workers. While these appointments help institutions function and improve faculty-student ratios on paper, they leave many PhD-holders trapped in precarious employment. When young talent sees the realities of academic life, many conclude that a career in research is neither stable nor rewarding. Unsurprisingly, some of our brightest minds choose to leave India. A nation cannot aspire to be a knowledge superpower while treating knowledge workers as expendable.

The solutions are neither simple nor quick. They involve governments, regulators, universities, faculty, students, and industry. Yet a logical starting point would be to reform the rankings and rating systems that have incentivised many of these distortions. India must stop measuring its success primarily through international league tables. Our national ranking and accreditation frameworks should be redesigned to reward sound practices and robust processes, not merely headline outcomes. Measures such as the National Institutional Rankings Framework's retraction penalty are a welcome first step, but they address symptoms, not the cause. The deeper problem lies in research metrics that prioritise quantity over quality and visibility over integrity.

We must also restore the value of teaching. Faculty salaries, particularly for researchers and early-career academics, need serious reconsideration. Accreditation bodies must place greater emphasis on fair compensation and humane working conditions for all scholars. If we build strong processes, nurture integrity, invest in people, and reward genuine excellence, the outcomes will take care of themselves. Sustainable success is never achieved by chasing numbers, it is achieved by building institutions worthy of them.

Achal Agrawal is founder, India Research Watch. The views expressed are personal

{ PEDRO SÁNCHEZ } PRIME MINISTER, SPAIN

What we are experiencing is not a series of isolated incidents. It is the consequence of a climate emergency that is making wildfires even more violent, heat waves more frequent

On the causes of the ongoing wildfires in Spain and France

Treat all Hepatitis B cases immediately to save lives

Two infections had comparable global death tolls in 2024: Tuberculosis (TB) killed 1.23 million, and Hepatitis B 1.1 million, while HIV-related illnesses killed 630,000. For Hepatitis B, the toll was 17% more than it was in 2015. In 2021, Hepatitis B consumed an estimated 21.5 million disability-adjusted life-years (DALYs). Nearly 30-35 million in India suffer from this infection and about 5-10 million may eventually die due to cirrhosis and liver cancer. Yet public recognition, political attention, and funding are strikingly unequal, with Hepatitis B receiving very low quanta of each. No wonder, the world, including India will miss the 2030 WHO targets — instead of the 90% targeted, diagnosing merely 3-15%, and the 80% targeted, treating just 5% of infected. Less than a million are receiving treatment despite a large National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme (NVHCP) since 2018.

SK Sarin

The problem is the medical profession itself. Unlike HIV and Hepatitis C (another liver virus causing cirrhosis and cancer) where every patient receives treatment, for Hepatitis B, medical algorithms demand high viral load, abnormal liver enzymes, liver scarring or fibrosis for getting treatment. Patients who fail to qualify must undergo repeated blood tests, viral-DNA measurements, fibrosis assessments, specialist consultations throughout life. As the virus remains silent for years, patients are often told to wait. This becomes a painful ordeal. The system spends money monitoring the virus, refusing to suppress it, while hurting the psyche of the infected. These recommendations originate mostly in western countries where tests and drugs are expensive.

A ray of hope, though, came last month. The new Asian guidelines on Hepatitis B, recommend "Treat All" rather than "Treat Select". The generic antivirals are low-cost in retail and also available under the NHVCP, and should cost less than ₹1,000 for a daily pill for a month. Pills taken daily can effectively suppress the virus for life with minimal adverse event and resistance. After China, India houses the largest number of Hepatitis B subjects. India should adopt a "test once, treat early and monitor simply" approach. Broadening treatment would not only reduce the DALY burden but also lower the several-fold higher cost of treatment for cirrhosis, cancer and transplantation for patients. India must adopt the Asian guidelines and reverse the expensive misallocation of scarce health resources in testing to treatment. Ghana showed that using conventional criteria made about only 10% of patients eligible, but by treating anyone with detectable Hepatitis B DNA raised eligibility to 87%. Health systems should stop spending scarce resources proving that people with Hepatitis B are not yet sick enough to treat. India will save substantially by screening households of infected and treating most, and early. Developing its own national cost-effectiveness model, using Indian prices, disease progression, adherence, cancer costs, productivity, and procurement rates would help.

If the Hepatitis B virus (HBV) is suppressed, the risk of transmission to the family and close contacts is negligible. One's own risk of cirrhosis and liver cancer falls markedly. This changes expenditure from high-cost rescue care for a small number of very sick patients to low-cost prevention distributed across a much larger population. We, the doctors, present the hurdle: Physicians must stop being gatekeepers who certify when Hepatitis B has caused enough damage. They should become preventers who ensure it never does.

We need to do a lot to reduce the stigma of Hepatitis B, very often associated with HIV. We need to join the EMPATHY (Empowering People Against Hepatitis) campaign. Physicians should explicitly state in certificates and counselling that ordinary social and workplace contact does not spread HBV. They should challenge inappropriate employment exclusion, refusal of procedures, and marriage-related misinformation.

Treating the infected should be strongly supplemented by protecting the next generation. HBV vaccine given at birth and followed by week 6, 10 and 14 can protect nearly every newborn. India has taken good strides in this direction, but much more can be done. Every adult should also get this most economical and effective vaccine.

July 28 is World Hepatitis Day; this time, it is being observed with the theme "Hepatitis: Let us break it down". We need to break the barriers, starting with social acceptance and dignity for the infected, change in attitude of the physicians to "Treat Most", and supportive policies of treatment and funding by the government. Every single Hepatitis B death is a reminder of our inept policies and delayed judgement. Act now, and, collectively to eliminate hepatitis B.

SK Sarin is professor of eminence, Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal

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WORLD

US astronaut Anil Menon set to do maiden spacewalk

WASHINGTON: Astronaut Anil Menon is set to undertake his first spacewalk next week as he steps out of the International Space Station to upgrade solar arrays, replace a comm antenna and fix new cables to support orbital lab operations. Menon, who traces his origins to Palakkad in Kerala, will undertake the walks beginning August 6. **PTI**

Indian-origin woman shot dead in Canada; 1 held

TORONTO: A 26-year-old Indian-origin woman was shot dead in Toronto and a man of Indian descent was arrested for her murder, police said. The victim was identified as Navneet Kaur, while the accused was Sharnjeet Singh, 37. **PTI**

Hasina charged in B'desh with crimes against humanity

DHAKA: Bangladesh's International Crimes Tribunal prosecution on Monday filed formal charges against deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina and 40 others in a crimes against humanity case related to a crackdown on a rally in Dhaka in 2013. **PTI**

Ukraine strikes on Russia kill five including child

MOSCOW: Ukraine fired hundreds of drones at Russia early Monday, killing five people including a child, according to Russian officials, AFP reported. Russian drone attacks on port infrastructure in Ukraine killed one and damaged three vessels, Reuters said. **AGENCIES**

Drones strike Gulf nations as Tehran tests Trump pause

Reuters
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DUBAI: Saudi Arabia, Jordan and Iraq reported drone attacks on Monday, two days after the United States abruptly suspended a two-week campaign of airstrikes against Iran, as Tehran appeared to put President Donald Trump's latest strategic U-turn to the test.

Saudi Arabia said it shot down drones aimed at petroleum targets, including in the capital Riyadh. It said the drones had been launched from Iraq by Iran-backed armed groups, and it reserved the right to respond.

Separately, Iran's Houthi allies in Yemen said they had targeted transit sites carrying oil to Saudi Arabia's main Red Sea oil port of Yanbu, in retaliation for what they said were Saudi drone incursions into Yemeni airspace.

Earlier, Jordan reported shooting down two drones, and Iraqi security sources reported a series of drone attacks in northern Iraq. Officials did not identify the sources of those drones.

Jordan and northern Iraq were the locations where four US service members were killed during the two-week air campaign, which Trump suspended abruptly over the weekend after his top brass advised him that the strategy had run its course.

Iran has said it is not seeking to resume peace talks with the US, although it would pause its own attacks for as long as Trump's ceasefire continues.

It also said it was still in control of the contested Strait of Hormuz, the key waterway for global energy supplies which Trump has demanded vessels be able to pass through freely.

The end of the US campaign sent oil prices tumbling. Brent crude fell around 6.5% on Monday to just over $90.

Trump's decision to suspend the campaign reflected advice from his military that the bombing had reached the limits of what it could achieve, according to a US official and several US media reports. The US official said military commanders had advised the president they were running out of targets.

(Top) Vessels in Hormuz near Bandar Abbas beach on Monday; (above) a satellite image shows smoke coming out of an oil facility in Abqaiq, Saudi Arabia that can process 7 million barrels daily, after it was struck by Houthis. REUTERS

IRAN AND OMAN TALKS FOCUS ON REOPENING STRAIT

KUWAIT/LONDON: Negotiators from Iran and Oman are trying to reach an agreement to restart shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, according to people familiar with the matter.

Iran and Oman, whose territories border the strait, are continuing discussions after their officials met in Tehran over the weekend, the people said, asking not to be identified talking about sensitive matters. A successful deal would then enable the Islamic Republic and the US to resume talks over ending their war, they said.

One proposal is to reopen the strait's so-called middle passage, said two of the people. That has largely been avoided by ships since the start of the conflict in late February, with vessels taking either a northern route close to Iran's shores or a southern one that passes near the Omani exclave of Musandam.

Omani negotiators are optimistic they'll be able to make an announcement signaling progress in the next few days, the people said. **BLOOMBERG**

Indians account for nearly 60% of Canada's PR decline

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
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TORONTO: While the number of new permanent residents in Canada declined by an eighth in the first five months of this year from the same period in 2025, Indians alone account for nearly 60% of the decrease.

According to the latest for permanent resident (PR) admissions released by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC), the total between January and May last year was 168,800, and that reduced to 147,260 this year or just over 12.5%.

Indians as a country cohort comprised the bulk of that fall, going down from 49,115 to 36,910 or by nearly a quarter.

The overall decline for the five-month stretch was 21,540 and Indians made for over 57% of the reduction.

"When the government sharply reduces a stream in which one country is disproportionately represented, that country inevitably absorbs a disproportionate share of the cut," Jack Jedwab, president of the Association for Canadian Studies, told the outlet National Post, though his comments were related to a similar trend detected in the first quarter of this year. In that period, Indians comprised 48% of the total decline and that trend has strengthened in the following pair of months.

Jedwab added, "Canada has moved from rapid immigration expansion to a deliberate, government-driven contraction."

IRCC has said it is "committed to returning immigration to sustainable levels, stabilising the number of new permanent residents each year to less than 1%" of the country's total population beyond 2027 with a focus on giving PR "to people already living in, working in, and contributing" to Canada.

According to IRCC data, there were 393,530 new permanent immigrants to Canada in 2025 compared to 483,655 in 2024, marking a 19% reduction in their numbers. Much of the decrease was also driven by the decline in immigrants from India seeking permanent residency in Canada, with their numbers going down from 127,375 to 98,770. The number of Indian permanent residents admitted to Canada rose sharply from just 42,875 in 2020 to a peak of 139,790 in 2023.

{ INDIAN CINEMA ALSO ADAPTED HIS STORIES } 1958-2026

Keigo Higashino, Japanese author of mysteries and thrillers, dies at 68

Agencies
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TOKYO: Japanese mystery fiction author Keigo Higashino has died aged 68, his publisher said on Monday, triggering an outpouring of grief among fans across Asia, AFP reported. Since his 1985 debut, Higashino wrote more than 100 books, with much of his work widely translated and adapted for film and television.

"Author Keigo Higashino passed away due to colon cancer in the early morning of July 23. He was 68," publisher Kodansha said in a statement.

A statement posted on Higashino's X account said that the author passed away in the early hours of last Thursday.

"Higashino's published works, from his debut novel 'After School', released in September 1985, to his latest book 'Eternal Memory', scheduled for release on August 5, 2026, total 106 books (excluding co-authored works)," the statement read.

"The stories he created will continue to captivate many readers," the statement said.

Keigo Higashino

Higashino, whose books include "The Devotion of Suspect X" and "Malice", enjoyed a loyal following around Asia, including in China where thousands of people took to social media to mourn the writer.

His novels Burutasu No Shinzou and The Devotion of Suspect X were respectively adapted as the Hindi language movies Monica, O My Darling (2022) and Jaane Jaan (2023).

Other works included "The Keeper of the Camphor Tree" which was turned into an animated film, and the "Galileo" series of detective novels which became a live-action TV series.

"Thank you very much. Your 'Detective Galileo' series was the first novel I bought. Thank you very much for giving me the best reading experience ever," said one Japanese user on X.

Another posted: "Seriously? Unbelievable, please someone tell me this is a lie." "Ever since I took up Mr. Higashino's novel as a teen, my life as a book lover started. His novels stunned me, influenced me and made me experience a whole range of emotions. These are all treasures of mine," added a third. In China, the passing of the Japanese novelist quickly became one of the top trending topics on social media platform Weibo.

Despite the volatile diplomatic ties between Beijing and Tokyo, his works have long been massively popular among readers in China. "The Miracles of the Namiya General Store" sold more than 10 million copies within its first four years in the mainland Chinese market, according to Chinese news portal ifeng.com.

THREE KILLED IN SHOOTING IN SEATTLE; 1 HELD, 1 SUSPECT ON RUN

Associated Press
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SEATTLE: Police searched for a second suspect Monday after gunfire erupted at a crowded food festival beneath Seattle's Space Needle, leaving three people dead and four others wounded, including a toddler. Another suspect, a 15 year old, was earlier arrested. Police said the two suspects were shooting at each other Sunday and one remained on the loose. Police did not have a description of the outstanding suspect, he said.

Two people died at the scene and a third died at a hospital. They were described as two men, ages 19 and 44, and a 56-year-old woman.

The four wounded, including a 2-year-old boy, were hospitalized and in stable condition early Monday, police said. The rest of the wounded were adults.

The gunfire erupted a 6pm Sunday (local time) during the Bite of Seattle, an annual three-day festival that draws hundreds of food and retail vendors and performers.

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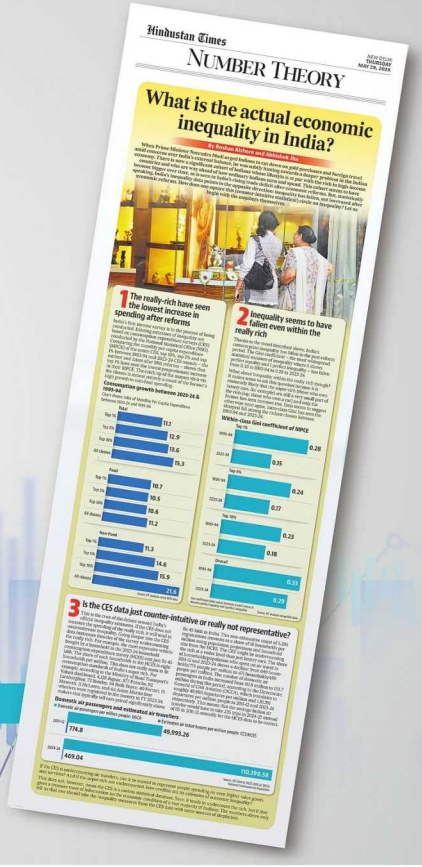

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Tata Sons' new ventures sink deeper into losses

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Overall, losses at Tata Sons' 16 privately held businesses nearly doubled in FY26. MINT

MUMBAI: The private businesses of Tata Sons envisioned to take the conglomerate to its next stage of growth sank deeper into losses in FY26, led by aviation, digital commerce, electronics assembling and battery manufacturing. Overall, losses at Tata Sons' 16 privately held businesses nearly doubled in FY26, rising to ₹27,854 crore from ₹15,311 crore in FY25, the Tata Sons annual report published on Monday showed.

In the annual report, Tata Sons chairman Chandrasekaran compared the ongoing large investments to Tatas' earlier endeavours like the Indian Institute of Science, steelmaking, software services, and fundamental research. "Each of these bets looked audacious, even imprudent, at the time they were made. Each took decades to prove itself. And each, in hindsight, turned out to be exactly what the nation needed," he wrote in his letter to shareholders.

"Losses in a diversified business group should be evaluated through the prism of the business lifecycle rather than in isolation," said Monish G. Chatrath, managing partner at MGC Global Risk Advisory, a risk consulting firm. Businesses in aviation, digital platforms, advanced manufacturing, and semiconductor ecosystems often require significant upfront investment and longer gestation periods before they achieve sustainable profitability, he said. "From a risk management perspective, the critical question is not whether losses arise during an investment phase, but whether they are accompanied by disciplined capital allocation, effective execution and measurable progress against clearly defined strategic milestones," he said.

Air India remained the loss-leader in FY26. Its losses more than doubling to ₹22,238 crore in a forgettable year where the carrier endured one of India's worst aviation disasters in recent history, and later bore the brunt of a surge in fuel costs as the Gulf war broke out. The airline's revenue declined by nearly a tenth to ₹71,870 crore.

"This year, Air India faced three external headwinds. Air space closures; West Asia conflict-driven fuel price hikes and foreign exchange fluctuations; and the crash of AI171 made it the most challenging year for Air India," Chandrasekaran wrote.

Tata Digital, which houses the e-commerce application Tata Neu, continued to be the second biggest loss-maker, losing ₹4,974 crore during the year with revenues of ₹35,990 crore. Tata Electronics, the group's foray into smartphone assembly and semiconductor manufacturing, was the group's highest grossing private business in FY26, surpassing Air India. The company's revenue doubled year-on-year to ₹1.3 trillion. However, the iPhone contract manufacturer also reported a deeper loss at ₹1,611 crore compared to ₹70 crore lost in the previous year.

Lastly, Agratas, which is making two giga factories for battery manufacturing, one each in India and the UK, reported a loss of ₹1,101 crore compared to ₹741 crore.

The business is yet to start commercial operations. Tata Sons invested ₹1,465 crore in the company during FY26.

The other dozen unlisted companies of Tata Sons made a cumulative profit of ₹2,070 crore compared to ₹969 crore in the previous year.

Air India revival may take a decade: Chandra

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N. Chandrasekaran,chairman, Tata Sons. REUTERS

Tata Sons has reset expectations for Air India's revival, with chairman N. Chandrasekaran telling shareholders that building a global airline is a five- to 10-year effort rather than a matter of quarters, signalling the turnaround will take longer than originally envisaged.

The comments, made in Tata Sons' FY26 annual report released on Monday, are the first time Chandrasekaran has publicly framed Air India's transformation over such a long horizon since the Tata Group regained control of the airline in January 2022.

"Every great airline in history was built over decades, not quarters," Chandrasekaran wrote. "Given where it began, Air India's transformation must be seen as a five- to ten-year journey, considering the years-long supply chain disruptions in key components, the need to overhaul legacy systems, culture and fleet, and the creation of a large cadre of technical and airline professionals."

He described the task as rebuilding the airline through "fleet renewal, training, service transformation and network expansion."

The remarks effectively extend the timeline beyond Vihaan.AI, the five-year transformation programme unveiled in September 2022 under outgoing chief executive Campbell Wilson to restore profitability and rebuild Air India into a world-class carrier.

Instead, FY26 became Air India's toughest year since returning to the Tata fold. The closure of Pakistani airspace from April 2025, the fatal AI171 crash in June of same year, the conflict in West Asia and higher fuel costs disrupted operations, while aircraft delivery delays constrained expansion.

Air India also cut several domestic and international routes to stem losses. Wilson, meanwhile, announced his resignation in April and is expected to step down in September. A successor is yet to be announced.

HDFC Bank fines 3 top executives in MSRDC case

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The matter pertains to the bank's arrangement with MSRDC for garnering deposits in 2017 and 2021. MINT

MUMBAI: HDFC Bank's board on Monday issued warning letters and levied a ₹1 lakh penalty on three top officials of the bank, after announcing the completion of an internal review for the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) issue.

These officials include managing director and chief executive officer Sashidhar Jagdishan, chief financial officer Srinivasan Vaidyanathan, and Arvind Vohra, group head for retail assets.

In a filing with the exchanges, the bank said it has also issued warning letters to other employees involved in the case.

The matter pertains to the bank's arrangement with MSRDC for garnering deposits in 2017 and 2021, as reported by *Indian Express* on 27 May. The report alleged that HDFC Bank made payments of ₹45 crore to MSRDC—routed as marketing expenses—to effectively offer higher returns on its deposits with the bank.

The newspaper report had also claimed that internal records reviewed during the probe pointed to discussions involving senior management, including Jagdishan. The payments were allegedly structured as 'differential interest' linked to deposits from MSRDC, but were routed through the bank's marketing department and shown as contributions towards a road safety awareness campaign involving local vendors, instead of being directly booked as interest payouts.

In a meeting on 23 July, the board concluded that the conduct of the employees involved constituted "business overreach" rather than any mala fide action, personal enrichment, or improper motive.

However, keeping in view "any potential divergence with the applicable RBI Directions and based on the recommendations of the Special Disciplinary Committee of Independent Directors", it decided to issue warning letters and monetary penalty.

When the issue first came to light, HDFC Bank had said that it has robust internal oversight, audit and control processes and systems, and that full process is always followed before final determination post any internal review. It also rejected any assumptions of wrongdoing or culpability "based on selective material".

"The only way to close these issues is to actually impose some level of penalty. This is not such a massive control breach, and nobody really has defaulted the bank or committed a fraud," said Abizer Diwanji, Founder - NeoStrat Advisors LLP. "It was a commercial negotiation, which has been implemented in a rather crude manner."

HDFC Bank notified the exchanges post market hours on Monday. Shares of the lender ended 0.4% lower at ₹739.55 on the NSE.

The board's decision appears to be an attempt to draw a line between commercial overreach and dishonest intent, said Soumya Singh, co-founding partner, Thistle&Law, adding that the absence of mala fide intent, however, does not automatically eliminate accountability from a governance perspective.

Number of billionaires grows 4-fold in 5 yrs to 576 in AY'26

NEW DELHI: As many as 576 individuals have reported a gross total income of ₹100 crore or more in their income tax returns (ITRs) in the 2025-26 assessment year (AY), registering a 4-fold growth over the past five years, Parliament was informed on Monday.

This was stated by Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary in the Lok Sabha in reply to a question on whether the government is aware that there has been a significant increase in the number of billionaires in the country and that it is among the leading nations in the world in this regard.

In a written reply, Chaudhary said there is no statutory definition of the term 'billionaire' either under the Income-tax Act, 2025 or under the erstwhile Income-tax Act, 1961.

However, the number of individuals having reported gross total income of ₹100 crore or more in the ITRs filed in AY 2025-26 stood at 576. PTI

BoB 1TB data breach linked to staff email

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MUMBAI: Bank of Baroda has suffered a cyber breach that reportedly exposed about 1TB of customer and internal data after an employee's email account was compromised, the public sector lender said.

The leaked files include branch audit reports, loan appraisal files, vigilance records and customer account-opening forms, among other documents circulating online. The bank said its core banking systems were not accessed and has launched a forensic investigation.

The archive is said to contain savings and current account records, loan documents, Net-Banking user details, Aadhaar numbers, NRI and corporate banking records, customer support files, and branch- and ATM-related information.

The breach came to light on 25 July after it was flagged by dark web monitoring platform ransomware.live, said Srikanth Lakshmanan, founder of fintech consumer collective CashlessConsumer. He said he verified a range of internal documents, including branch audit reports, loan appraisal files, internal communications, vigilance investigation records, bobWorld audit reports and customer account-opening forms from multiple branches.

The bank confirmed the incident on Monday afternoon through a post on 'X', "The incident involved compromise of an employee's email account, resulting in unauthorised access to certain data. The matter was promptly identified, and immediate containment measures were implemented. The Bank's core banking systems were not accessed and continue to remain secure," they said. The bank added that a comprehensive forensic investigation has been initiated and that it is working with the relevant authorities in accordance with applicable regulatory requirements.

The stock exchanges have separately sought a clarification from the bank on a 27 July media report about the data appearing on the dark web.

SC REJECTS SUN PHARMA PLEA IN INTAS' 'BEVATAS' TRADEMARK ROW

Utkarsh Anand
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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed Sun Pharma Laboratories' appeal against a Delhi High Court judgment permitting Ahmedabad-based Intas Pharmaceuticals to manufacture and market its anti-cancer drug under the trademark 'Bevatas', saying that there was no likelihood of confusion with Sun Pharma's registered trademark 'Bevetex'.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and comprising justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana affirmed the high court's finding that the rival marks did not create a likelihood of confusion among the relevant class of consumers, including oncologists, chemists, trained nurses, patients and their attendants.

The bench also agreed with the high court that the two medicines were not therapeutic substitutes and, therefore, could not be treated as identical or even closely similar goods for the purposes of trademark infringement.

SC MAY HAND OVER PARSVNATH PROBE TO CBI, EOW

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday indicated that it may hand over the investigation into the affairs of Parsvnath Developers Ltd and Parsvnath Hessa Developers Pvt Ltd to the Economic Offences Wing (EOW) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), describing the alleged fraud perpetrated on homebuyers as a "high-level fraud" requiring a comprehensive probe across all projects.

A bench comprisingCJI Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana directed the interim resolution professional (IRP) for Parsvnath Developers Ltd, which is undergoing corporate insolvency resolution proceedings (CIRP), and Parsvnath Hessa to furnish exhaustive details of all pending litigation against them, saying the exercise was necessary to ascertain the full extent of the alleged fraud and the number of affected homebuyers. UTKARSH ANAND

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

1 Book transport for a group (7)
5 Rope in a girl with a ring (5)
8 Wild lion scared no one; certainly not him (9)
9 Biochemistry for member of a West African people (3)
10 Blow on the foot for warmth (4)
12 Pains grip sick Greek hero (8)
14 Ice cold (6)
15 In Latin 'I' is used by many showing selfishness (6)
17 An A for apprenticeship (8)
18 Small soft cry (4)
21 Margaret shortly turned to stone (3)
22 Talk of past crimes in Egyptian capital maybe (9)
24 Sedan built for the likes of Schmeichel or Wozniacki? (5)
25 Used by writer and poet perhaps (7)

DOWN

1 Salvo possible but not rounds (5)
2 Agree but say nothing (3)
3 Harbour bar in which business is unusually brisk (4)
4 Go for the best (6)
5 Ties even if beatings are evident (8)
6 Painting that lacks humanity? (5,4)
7 This animal won't always die a natural death (7)
11 Skilled worker in the main? (9)
13 Pure ices for them of course (8)
14 New-fangled sort of wheel (7)
16 Indispensable member of locksmith's staff? (3,3)
19 Quietly start to pray (5)
20 Some soldiers can return to university (4)
23 A detergent without a special offer (3)

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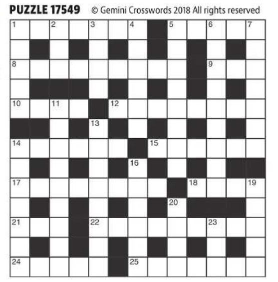

QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1 Thorough and detailed (2-5)
5 Student (5)
8 Being exhibited (2,7)
9 Portion of a curve (3)
10 Be open wide (4)
12 Impartial (8)
14 French (6)
15 Sumptuous environment (6)
17 Unquestioning (8)
18 Marjoram, for example (4)
21 Lion's foot (3)
22 With reference to (2,7)
24 Before due time (5)
25 Propose (7)

DOWN

1 Elephant tusk (5)
2 Useless (3)
3 Attitude assumed for effect (4)
4 Rob at gunpoint (4,2)
5 Bodily structure (8)
6 Commonplace remark (9)
7 In a particular area (7)
11 Self-discipline (9)
13 Armed forces (8)
14 Momentary view (7)
16 River of Iraq (6)
19 Hemmed in (5)
20 Eagerly expectant (4)
23 A cereal plant (3)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17548)

CRYPTIC

QUICK

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★

	1				2	5	3	
		5			3			
	2		1	4				8
6					7	4		
	8						5	
		4	6					9
8				3	6		2	
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	5	1	2				4	

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9X9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

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{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■HIGH ■LOW

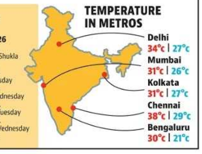
TUESDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain 30°c | 21°c

WEDNESDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain 30°c | 21°c

THURSDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain 31°c | 21°c

ALMANAC
Today is 28th July 2026
13 Safar, 1448
29, Ashadha, Shukla Paksha, 14
Samvat 2083
Sunset: Tuesday at 06:47 p.m.
Sunrise: Wednesday at 06:04 a.m.
Moonrise: Tuesday at 06:02 p.m.
Moonset: Wednesday at 05:37 a.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS



{ ANAHAT SINGH } JUNIOR WORLD CHAMPION

Squash: How Anahat ended a long wait for a 'desperate' goal

The 18-year-old is already competing on the senior circuit but this was one thing she wanted to tick off before her junior career ended

Rutvick Mehta
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MUMBAI: Anahat Singh is now a world junior squash champion—the first Indian and the first non-Egyptian woman since 2010 to sit on the throne. And yet the celebrations, by the Niagara Falls where she's presently, have to be put on ice.

The team events follow the individual competition, and Anahat has been asked to remain in the competitive zone a bit longer.

"I'll save the celebrations for the last day," she says, smiling.

Given how long the 18-year-old has waited to grab the title, a handful of days may feel like nothing in comparison.

For four years, the country's most decorated and one of the world's most promising young squash talents kept turning up at the junior worlds, and kept falling short. Three quarter-finals meant she stood a step away from a medal, and one semi-final last year meant she had a bronze but not what she was after.

That, despite rapidly growing in stature on the senior professional tour, shooting up to the top-20 of the PSA rankings, gobbling up 16 PSA titles and being an Asian Games medallist. Why, then, did a junior title still matter so much to her?

"I mean, it's still the world juniors," Anahat told HT on a Zoom call from Ontario, Canada, two days after finally standing on top of the podium with a win over Egypt's Ruqayya Salem in the final.

"It's the biggest event for any junior, and I was still a junior whether I was playing the seniors or not. This was also my fifth year playing, and I would always lose coming really close to it. I wanted to break that, and show that I can win this event. It's something that I wanted to tick off, and something I wanted to be satisfied with—that I've ended my junior career well."

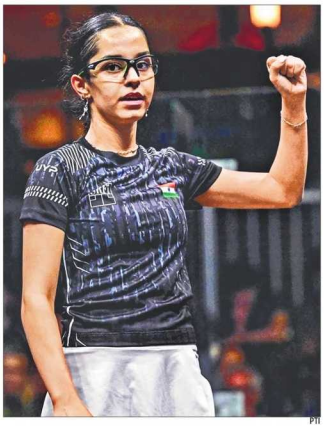
There was almost a sense of desperation in her around chasing that one medal. Would desperate be the right term?

"Yeah, definitely," Anahat said. "I wanted this badly."

How does a teenager mentally handle something she wants so desperately?

"I mean, I didn't handle it very well for the last few years," Anahat admitted. "I knew this was my last chance, and there was literally no going back from this. So I had to just focus, and stay in it. I knew I was ranked 1 (top seed) in this event, and I was expected to win."

Speaking earlier in the day in a media interaction organised by SAI, Anahat said she felt "a little bit of extra pressure" coming into this edition knowing it was her last chance. From her past faltering experiences, she knew the only way to counter it was to, well, stop thinking about the past. It wasn't quite working. In her quarters and semis, Anahat felt she did not play too well, "because I was getting too stressed out". Long conversations with her mentor Saurav Ghosal, who was with her in Ontario, before and on the day of the final eventually eased her out.


PTI

"He was like, 'You're playing really badly. This is not how you need to be playing. If you really want to win tomorrow (final day), just go all out. Don't think about the outcome, don't think about anything else. You have the game to beat everyone in this event'," Anahat recalled Ghosal's words on the Zoom call.

"So, having that conversation with him, being able to focus on playing my game, and just remembering that I've played against the top-10, top-20 players. And if I'm able to beat them, I can play a lot better here. That mentality just helped me a lot more. In the final, I wasn't stressed at all, I'd say maybe 10%. I was playing freely, and just enjoying every moment on court."

> Had I lost this event, I would have been a bit unsatisfied — that I have kept playing juniors for the last 8-10 years, I've been doing decently well but I've not ended it on a good note
>
> **ANAHAT SINGH,** India's top woman squash player

What also gave her more confidence was playing more tournaments on the PSA tour. Anahat won the JSW Indian Open in March this year, before taking a short break to appear for her 12th grade exams. On her return, she lost in the first round of the British Open. That "did put a few doubts in my mind" about her junior worlds conquest, before a 15-day training block in Prague with coach Gregory Gaultier shooed it away.

"I knew that I can completely reset the whole thing. I was playing in training, and felt quite good coming into this event. The stakes of it being my last shot, the whole adrenaline of the situation just added up to it."

At one point during the last couple of years, the thought that maybe she was not meant to get that title, that maybe it was time to set new goalposts, did cross her mind. But she also knew that all she needed was one last shot. She hit bull's-eye with it, and is now freer in the mind.

"Had I lost this event, I would have been a bit unsatisfied — that I have kept playing juniors for the last 8-10 years, I've been doing decently well but I've not ended it on a good note," she said.

"I think this helps a lot in my transition as well into the seniors. It gives me the confidence going into it that one chapter is closed, it was closed well, and I can start off this one well."

The biggest chapter of this year, however, still awaits. The Asian Games has much higher stakes, the cherry being a spot at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics for the gold medallist. This title helps in adding a bit of belief, but Anahat also knows they are two different worlds.

"It definitely does help a bit, but I wouldn't say it does too much," she said. "It makes me happy. It gives me confidence that I can play well and do well at the top stage. But, this was the juniors, and that is the seniors. The situation is very, very different."

Which is why after a few days of enjoying this triumph, Anahat will go right back into training, "to make sure I'm at my peak at the Asian Games".

"Right now, the Asian Games is the most important event of my life. So I have to put in 100% for that, and, hopefully, it can all work out for the good."

Esha clinches gold, Manu bags bronze

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HANGZHOU: Esha Singh grabbed gold by upstaging Olympic-medallist Manu Bhaker, who took the bronze to complete a double-podium finish for India in the women's 25m pistol event of the ISSF World Cup.

The 21-year-old Esha produced a commanding display in the final, registering 40 hits to seal gold, while Manu fought through a tense, highly-competitive field, winning a crucial shoot-off before finishing with 28 hits to secure bronze.

The Indian squad set the benchmark early in the qualification round. Manu topped the qualifying with a score of 586-20x, closely followed by Esha in second place with 585-18x.

Former Asian Games gold-medallist Rahi Sarnobat posted 582-16x, while Simranpreet Kaur Brar (576-20x) and Abhidnya Ashok Patil (573-16x) delivered steady shows competing under Ranking Points Only (RPO) status.

Reflecting on overcoming the mental pressure following her record-setting World Cup gold in Munich earlier this season, Esha said, "This match was very pressure-riding for me because of the previous medal I had. The better you get in your event, the more you feel that weight of prestige you have to conquer. I'm happy that I was able to get past it today and grateful that I had the ability to endure it.

Esha Singh. HT

"I really love competing here in Hangzhou. Recalling how the competition went during the Asian Games, where I won four medals, I was really excited to come back. Being familiar with the range, the lighting, and the atmosphere in the final hall definitely counted in my favour."

Indian paddlers make solid start

NEW DELHI: Top seeded Indian men's and women's teams registered identical 3-0 victories over Zimbabwe and Maldives respectively as the hosts made a commanding start to their campaign in the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships. Malaysia also opened with a 3-0 victory over Wales in the same group at the Thyagraj Stadium.

Pirlo out of running for Italy coach's job

ROME: Andrea Pirlo is out of contention for the Italy job amid political concerns over a sponsorship deal with a Russian betting firm. The flap over Pirlo has Paolo Maldini considering stepping down just 16 days into his new job as the technical director. This after Pep Guardiola and Carlo Ancelotti had already turned down offers to coach the national team.

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HT FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Gyaneshwari fights hard for silver, Bindyarani wins bronze

The two medals brought India's overall weightlifting medal tally to an impressive five

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India's Gyaneshwari Yadav celebrates after wining silver in the women 53kg weightlifting during the CWG in Glasgow. AP

NEW DELHI: Weightlifter Gyaneshwari Yadav produced a power-packed performance to clinch a silver medal at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Monday. Inspired by her idol Mirabai Chanu completing a hat-trick of gold medals in CWG a day earlier, the 23-year-old won her maiden medal in the women's 53kg weight division.

Gyaneshwari went toe-to-toe with Nigeria's Onome Omolola Didih in the battle for gold before eventually settling for silver. The Indian lifted a total of 199kg (88kg in snatch and 111kg in clean and jerk), while Didih claimed the gold with a stunning total of 206kg (93kg + 113kg). Both weightlifters improved on the Commonwealth Games records with the Nigerian eventually putting herself on top.

Seasoned Bindyarani Devi later added a bronze in the women's 58kg weight category. She lifted 87kg in snatch and 112kg in clean and jerk for a total lift of 199kg.

After Mirabai's gold, India's Raja Muthupandi won silver in the men's 65kg late on Sunday. The 26-year-old from Kovilpatti, Tamil Nadu cleared one attempt each in snatch and clean and jerk (126+160=286), which was good for second. Malaysia's Azril Bin Bidin Muhamad (133+166=299) set three Games records while claiming gold with ease. Morea Baru of Papua New Guinea took bronze (125+157=282).

On Monday, the highlight was Gyaneshwari's feisty show against Nigerian Omolola Didih who was on a record breaking spree.

Gyaneshwari began with an 82kg lift in her first snatch attempt before gradually increasing the weight in her next two attempts, successfully lifting 85kg and 88kg. Didih opened with 85kg before adding 5kg in her second attempt and then lifting 93kg in her third, setting a new Commonwealth and Commonwealth Games records.

Trailing Didih by just 5kg after the snatch, Gyaneshwari kept herself firmly in contention in the clean and jerk. She opened with 103kg before adding 4kg to the barbell for her second attempt, successfully lifting 107kg to set a new Commonwealth Games record.

Didih, however, was not to be outdone. After opening with a successful lift of 105kg, she raised the bar to 110kg to reclaim the record. Gyaneshwari then lifted 111kg in her final attempt, putting the pressure back on the Nigerian. Didih held her nerve, clearing 113kg with her final lift to seal the gold medal and the record. Gyaneshwari, however, would be pleased with her effort as she recorded personal bests in both the snatch and clean and jerk. "I wanted to give my personal best here, and I am happy that I have been able to do that in such a tough competition," Gyaneshwari told PTI in Glasgow.

Hailing from Rajnandgaon district in Chhattisgarh, Gyaneshwari has long idolised Mirabai, who completed a hat-trick of Commonwealth Games gold medals on Sunday. The daughter of a bodybuilder, Gyaneshwari fell in love with weightlifting at a young age.

In 2022, she won a silver medal in the 49kg category at the World Junior Championships with a total lift of 156kg. The performance brought her into the limelight as she made a name for herself in the same weight category as her idol, Mirabai. "My father used to do bodybuilding, but due to our poor financial condition, he had to give it up. We moved from the village to the city," Gyaneshwari said.

"I used to do powerlifting, but when I saw how the weights progressed in weightlifting, I became very interested. So I told my father I wanted to take up weightlifting, and he was very supportive," she added. At the 2024 Senior World Championships, Gyaneshwari stepped into Mirabai's shoes in her absence, representing India in the 49kg category. She finished a creditable fifth with a total lift of 182kg. She has steadily progressed, displaying remarkable composure while learning from Mirabai at the national camp. With Mirabai competing in the 49kg category here, Gyaneshwari moved up to 53kg and delivered a memorable performance. She had tested herself in the new weight category at the Asian Championships in Gandhinagar earlier this year, where she won bronze with a total lift of 194kg.

Bindyarani Devi poses with her bronze medal. PTI

Bindyarani's weakness in snatch left her shaky for a while before a sensible weight call in clean and jerk helped her take bronze in the women's 58kg weightlifting competition. The 27-year-old was conservative in snatch, and her clearing 83, 85 and 87 left her in fourth position at the halfway mark.

Nigeria's Rafiatu Folashade Lawal was a force unto herself, powering to the gold medal with a snatch of 103 and a brilliant final clean and jerk of 126. Canada's Ann Sophie Taschereau was too strong for Bindyarani. After a snatch effort of 94—which left her second but 9kg behind the Nigerian lifter – Taschereau lifted 111, 115 and 121 to ease into the second spot. By then the Indian had a clear picture as she only had to do better than England's Eliza Pratt (87+109), whose second attempt in clean and jerk pushed her to fourth. Bindyarani had initially called for 113kg in clean and jerk, but smartly lowered the weight to 110kg, which she failed to clear. However, she returned determined and her second attempt of 112kg sealed the medal.

With 87kg in snatch and 112 in clean and jerk, she totalled only 199. A failed final try of 116kg meant she could not cross 200kg in total. The Nigerian was a class apart as she lifted 126kg in clean and jerk, 5kg better than Taschereau, yelling and jumping in triumph to celebrate the win.

Long jumper Sreeshankar, hurdler Shirse enter finals

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India's Murali Sreeshankar in action during the men's long jump qualifying round. REUTERS

NEW DELHI: Murali Sreeshankar eased into the long jump final on Monday, sealing his spot with a solitary jump to achieve the 8m cut-off with ease. The experienced jumper cleared 8.01m in his first and only attempt to advance to the final, which will be held at Scotstoun Stadium on Wednesday.

India will also be represented by Lokesh Sathyanathan in the 12-man medal round. Competing in his first Commonwealth Games (CWG), the 26-year-old NCAA athlete leapt 7.77m in his opening try and fouled his next two. His lone legal jump, however, was enough to take him to the final.

Sathyanathan's jump was fourth best in his lot, topped by 2019 world champion Tajay Gayle. The Jamaican logged a best of 8.10m after warming up with jumps of 7.74m and 7.40m. Saint Vincent's Uroy Ryan (8.04m) and Regan Corrin, representing Great Britain and Northern Ireland (7.84m) also finished ahead of Sathyanathan in Group B.

There was no catching Sreeshankar in Group A though. The 27-year-old was the only athlete to earn direct qualification from his group while five others made the finals as top-12 best performers.

A silver medallist at the 2022 edition of Commonwealth Games (CWG) in Birmingham, Sreeshankar will aim to go a step further in Glasgow. With a season's best of 8.38m achieved last month at the Inter-State Championship in Bhubaneswar, Sreeshankar enters the final in fine form, also evidenced by five consecutive wins leading into the Games.

"Qualification went quite well, it was tricky conditions for everyone. It was cold and windy and it was raining also in between but I qualified in the first attempt, so very excited for the final," Sreeshankar told PTI.

The weather is expected to be cold on Wednesday as well, with temperatures around 18°C and a 40 percent possibility of light showers throughout the day. The Indian athletics contingent had camped in Spala, Poland before coming to Glasgow to acclamaitise to the cold and wet conditions.

"At big events such as the CWG or Asian Games, distance alone doesn't matter too much," Sreeshankar had told HT before leaving for Europe.

"You should be able to adapt to the conditions and pressure. UK is usually cold and wet, so long jump is unlikely to produce big jumps. In such a scenario, you should be able to execute your technique well."

Having made a competitive return last year from a career-threatening knee injury -- a ruptured patellar tendon -- for which he underwent surgery two years back, Sreeshankar's resilience and preparation will be put to test on Wednesday.

National record holder in 100m hurdles, Tejas Shirse, also qualified for the final. Running in Lane 7 in Heat 1, Shirse clocked 13.76s to finish third, behind England's Samuel Bennett (13.20s) and Jamaica's Jerome Campbell (13.33s). Top three from both heats and the next two fastest runners advanced to the eight-man final that will be run late on Monday night (IST).

Overall, Shirse's qualification time put him seventh among eight finalists and was also his slowest race of the season. The 24-year-old Indian with a personal best and NR of 13.27s that he ran last month in Ludhiana, will look to course correct.

Despite being a force to reckon with at home, Shirse is yet to perform at the international stage. He had missed the 2023 editions of Asian Championships and Asian Games, Paris Olympics in 2024, and the World Indoors and Asian Championships in 2025. His 2025 World Championships qualification happened at the last moment when he entered in the 40th place — the last available slot — on rankings, after Cyprus' Milan Trajkovic and Australia's Tayleb Willis pulled out. He couldn't advance beyond heats at the Worlds, clocking 13.57s.

Shirse then injured his right ankle by the end of 2025, which put him out of action for four months. He has competed extensively since his return, but while he has remained unbeaten at home, he still awaits an international success of note.

"I don't consciously chase a time," Shirse had told HT before leaving for CWG. "The idea is to run a technically good race. I want to become a good, wholesome athlete and not someone who can run fast occasionally."

GURINDERVIR DISAPPOINTS, FAILS TO MAKE SEMI-FINALS

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NEW DELHI: For all the pre-Games hype surrounding him, India's fastest man Gurindervir Singh's performance in the 100m proved to be a damp squib. The 25-year-old ran a sub-par 10.39s to finish a disappointing 28th among 73 sprinters who competed.

Competing in Lane 5 in Heat 4, Gurindervir made a decent start and stayed alongside Jamaica's Rohan Watson through the early stages before the Jamaican powered away over the final 30-35 metres to win in 10.13 seconds.

Watson, who has a personal best of 9.91 seconds, opened a gap of around two metres. The result meant the Indian missed the semi-final cut-off for which 17 athletes qualified, the slowest among them clocked 10.24s.

The race was run with a legal tailwind of 1.5 m/s, but Gurindervir could not convert the favourable conditions. His 10.39 seconds was far from his best of 10.09 seconds, a national record that he set at the Federation Cup in Ranchi in May, when he became the first Indian to run under 10.10 seconds.

The race also underscored Gurindervir's inconsistency. His Federation Cup performance, where he ran 10.17s in the semi-final and 10.09 in the final, was preceded by a 10.44s at the Saudi Athletics Grand Prix in Riyadh and a 10.40s run at the Indian Athletics Series in New Delhi.

RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)

WEIGHTLIFTING
Men's 65kg
Raja Muthupandi won silver
Women's 53kg
Gyaneshwari Yadav won silver
Women's 58kg
Bindyarani Devi won bronze

ARTISTIC GYMNASTICS
Women's vault final
Protistha Samanta ended 7th

ATHLETICS
Men's 100m heats
Gurindervir Singh (10.39secs) was 2nd in heats, 28th overall and failed to qualify for semis
Men's long jump qualifying
M Sreeshankar and Lokesh Sathyanathan qualified for final
Men's 110m hurdles heats
Tejas Shirse qualified for final

SWIMMING
Men's 200m butterfly heats
Sajan Prakash qualified for final
Men's 100m breaststroke SB9 heats
Swatik Patil qualified for the final

BOXING
Men's 60kg Round of 16
Sachin Siwach beat William Hewitt (ENG) 4-1

Men's 80kg Round of 16
Ankush Panghal beat Zalaan Jan (ANT) 5-0
Women's 51kg Round of 16
Sakshi Chaudhary beat Lethabo Modukanele (BOT) 5-0
Men's 65kg Round of 16
Aditya Pratap Yadav lost 2-3 to Nuhu Batte (UGA)

BOWLS
Men's singles Group D
Putul Sonowal lost 0.5-1.5 to Anwar Hamada (KEN)

medalstally

	COUNTRY				
1	Australia	19	9	16	44
2	Canada	6	7	4	17
3	Nigeria	6	4	0	10
4	England	5	11	6	22
5	Scotland	4	3	1	8
8	INDIA	1	3	2	6

TILL MIDNIGHT

Boxers Sachin, Ankush storm into quarters with contrasting victories

Agencies
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

India's Ankush (red) competes against Antigua and Barbuda's Jan Zalaan. PTI

GLASGOW: Former world youth champion Sachin Siwach advanced to the quarter-finals of the men's 60kg boxing competition at the Commonwealth Games after defeating England's William Hewitt by a 4-1 points decision in the round of 16, on Monday.

The 26-year-old Sachin dominated the contest with consistent scoring across the three rounds. He won the first two rounds on four judges' cards before securing the overall verdict despite one judge scoring the bout in Hewitt's favour. The Indian then sealed the win despite a point deduction in the final round.

The victory puts Sachin one win away from a CWG medal as he next faces Botswana's Treasure Moremi in the quarters. Moremi defeated Lesotho's Toka Litabe in another last-16 contest by a 3-2 split decision.

"It turned out really well after listening to my coach. Now, the goal isn't just a medal; it's gold. That's what I had decided from the start: I'm going for gold. My first two fights there were tough, though the subsequent ones weren't as difficult. Still, I have to be fully prepared. I don't want to make mistakes," Sachin said.

Ankush produced a commanding performance in his Commonwealth Games debut, defeating Antigua and Barbuda's Zalaan Jan by a unanimous 5-0 decision to advance to the quarterfinals of the men's 80kg category of the 2026 edition.

The 20-year-old looked composed from the opening bell, landing accurate punches and controlling the pace of the bout with sharp counter-attacking. Ankush swept the first round with all five judges scoring in his favour after he connected with clean hooks and maintained a strong defensive approach, according to ESPN.

Building on his early advantage, Ankush continued to dictate the contest in the second round. He moved in and out of range effortlessly, frustrating Jan's attempts to mount an attack and once again secured a clean sweep from the judges.

With a commanding lead heading into the final round, Ankush stayed disciplined and focused on maintaining control. He landed a series of powerful combinations before following his coaches' instructions to keep his distance and avoid unnecessary exchanges.

Jan managed to find brief moments of success, including pinning Ankush against the ropes, but the Indian boxer remained in control and comfortably ran down the clock to complete a one-sided victory.

In another bout, Sakshi won by 5-0 against Lethabo Modukanele of Botswana in a Round of 16 bout.

Protistha finishes 7th

Protistha Samanta finished seventh in the women's vault final of artistic gymnastics on Monday. The 22-year-old from West Bengal, who had qualified seventh for the eight-woman final, averaged 12.883 after scoring 12.700 on her first vault and 12.666 on her second.

Canada's Lia-Monica Fontaine clinched gold with a commanding display. Fontaine, the top qualifier, successfully retained her lead in the final, averaging 14.000 from scores of 14.000 and 13.600. England's Abigail Martin claimed silver with 13.799, while Wales' Abigail Roper took bronze with 13.433.

Sajan qualifies for final

Two-time Olympian Sajan Prakash qualified for the men's 200m butterfly final after finishing as the sixth fastest swimmer overall in the heats. The Indian clocked 1:58.59sec to finish second in Heat 2 behind Scotland's Duncan Scott (1:58.29).

Australia's Harrison Turner topped the qualification standings with 1:56.47sec, followed by New Zealand's Lewis Clareburt (1:57.35) and England's Edward Mildred (1:57.99).

GLASGOW CORNER

England's Shantae-Eve Amankwaah in action during the women's uneven bars final. REUTERS

INSPIRED BY BEKAURI, DEBUTANT TOKAS CHASES INDIA'S FIRST CWG JUDO GOLD

Drawn to combat sports since childhood and inspired by two-time Olympic champion Lasha Bekauri of Georgia, Indian judoka Harsh Tokas is dreaming of creating history by winning India's first ever CWG gold in judo on his debut in Glasgow. The 23-year-old, who will compete in the men's 81kg category, fell in love with judo at the age of 10 after joining a free academy in Delhi's Munirka village. More than a decade later, the CWG represents the biggest stage of his career, and Tokas is determined to settle for nothing less than the top step of the podium. "I started judo about 12 years ago when I was around 10 or 11 years old. That is when my journey began," he told PTI.

OLYMPIC MEDALLISTS PULL OUT OF TEAM

Sprinter Louie Hinchliffe and 400m runner Charlie Dobson have withdrawn from England's athletics team. Both runners won bronze in relay events at the 2024 Paris Olympics but now will not feature in Glasgow. Nine English athletes, including Olympic silver medallist Katarina Johnson-Thompson and Dina Asher-Smith, had already withdrawn. England's only remaining sprinter in the 100m heats is Elliot Jones, who has a personal best of 10.04 seconds. Jones will also run in the 4x100m relay alongside Nethaneel Mitchell-Blake, Romell Glave and Ebuka Nwokeji.

RISHAB FOR CWG CLOSING CEREMONY

Sitar player Rishab Rikhiram Sharma is set to take the stage on August 2, delivering a neo-classical music performance at the closing ceremony of the Commonwealth Games. Sharma will share the stage with National Award-winning composer and singer Shankar Mahadevan (performing alongside his sons, Siddharth and Shivam). Together, they will headline India's explosive 20-minute cultural presentation, culminating in the formal flag handover ceremony to India as the host country for the upcoming 2030 centenary edition in Ahmedabad.